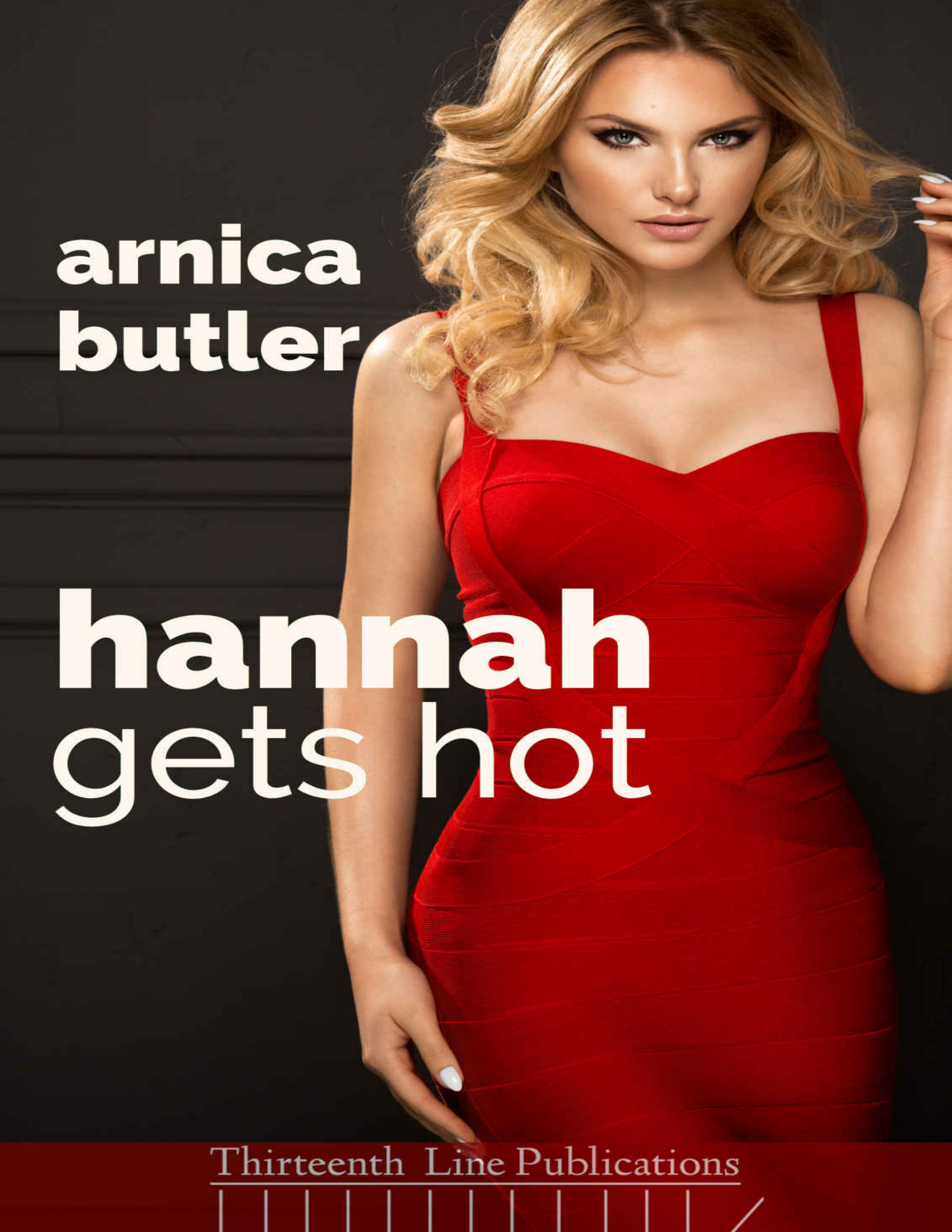




**arnica
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**hannah
gets hot**

Thirteenth Line Publications



HANNAH GETS HOT

A Story About Sharing A Wife

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

“How’d it go?”

Hannah was trying to edge through the door, drips of water sliding off her slicker. “Dammit,” she cursed, and it was hard to tell if the plastic crack that made the door give way was the result of her comment or the other way around. Mike grabbed the small suitcase she was using as a crowbar, and the door sprang back, nearly smashing her hand.

Hannah, ordinarily composed – an adjective most people used when describing her – let out an audible sigh, muttered a second, unintelligible swearword, and used a foot to stop the door. She peeked around the swinging door as she nudged it open with her elbow to see what she had broken, just as Mike dove in for a kiss.

They smacked their foreheads instead, and her hand flew up to her brow.

“Whoa. Sorry,” Mike said lamely, setting the suitcase to the side and pushing the door open for her to climb in from the garage. It was a climb because the middle step had rotted out long ago, and was on the “honey-do” list, where it seemed to be forever relegated to the land of future projects.

Hannah straightened herself, water dripping onto the tile, and pushed her damp hair from her face.

“Why were you out in the rain?” Mike asked, and then immediately wished he had said something else, because a look of pure annoyance crossed her face.

“The gate was locked,” she said sourly. But she was already regaining her composure, peeling her jacket off, assessing the situation with her paramedic’s eye. “What’d I break?” she added.

They both looked at the crumpled Exersaucer, an item both of their children were far too old for, which had been placed long ago in an ever-growing basement pile of donations that were forever forgotten by Mike and Hannah, and forever remembered and dredged up by Ella and Jake.

“What the heck is that doing up here?” she said, annoyed.

Mike smiled at her and helped her with her slicker. He was relieved that Hannah, whose flight was two hours late arriving in the piss-poor

weather, through which she'd also had to drive an additional hour and a half, was willing to change her mood. She always was.

She adjusted her wild shoulder-length, naturally bright blonde hair, and smiled back. "Let's start over," she said. "Hi."

Mike hung her coat up on a rack that looked more like an eight foot high pile of coats. "Hi," he said, and leaned in to kiss her. It was the kind of quick, perfunctory kiss that married people give to each other. "Come in. You want some hot tea or something?"

"Or something," Hannah groaned, kicking off her shoes and stepping into a pair she used for the house. "Man. That was a trek."

"I bet," Mike said. He was headed to the fridge, happy to comply with Hannah's unusual request for "or something," already thinking ahead to the possibility that tonight might be a lucky night for him, which was definitely unexpected given the circumstances.

"Kids already down?" Hannah asked, walking toward the stairs.

"Don't jinx it," Mike said.

"Guys?" she called, softly enough that if they were, by some miracle, asleep, they wouldn't respond. She loved them, for sure, but three days away had not been nearly enough to restore her sanity.

She gave up easily. "Probably on their tablets," she said.

Mike held up a bottle of wine and made a face. *Want some?*

Hannah hesitated. "Um... sure." She leaned on the counter.

"You want to sit?" Mike asked.

"God, no," Hannah replied, rubbing her back to emphasize that she had been sitting too long. Hannah was not a sitter. She was an outdoorsy, fast-action, move around at all times kind of girl. "So, what'd I miss?" she said, leafing through a junk magazine at the top of an enormous pile of mail.

Mike poured two glasses of wine, admiring the rare sight of Hannah's cleavage – small but perky breasts that had somehow remained unchanged by having two children. Granted, they were long past that stage now, but Hannah had made it through her pregnancies virtually unscarred.

"The usual. Jake is annoying Ella so, so, so much with his whistling, and Ella is annoying Jake so, so, so much with her... whatever it is she's doing."

"Scintillating," Hannah said, with a grin. They toasted the glasses of wine with a dull clink. All the good glasses were broken, and the last two

standing were an ultra-cheap, thick pair from the dollar store purchased ten years ago when they had first moved in together. They had enough money to buy more now, but no time to shop.

Or, ordinarily, drink wine out of them.

“So... other than the crappy flight, how was it?” Mike asked.

He thought he detected something, right then and there, but it didn’t really *alert* him. Hannah would ordinarily have made a smart-ass comment, right away, because she was quick-witted and had a friendly-but-cynical tone common to a lot of paramedics. Sort of optimistic gallows humor, if there was such a thing.

That night, though, she paused, squinting into her wine as though she needed some kind of guidance from a crystal ball. It was odd for Hannah to spend any time choosing her words: she was the all-time champion contributor to the Swear Jar on the shelf next to the cookies, into which she occasionally deposited cookies in irritation at having been caught, yet again, saying “fuck.”

“It was a good visit,” she said. “But three days is way too fast.”

The conversation unspooled from there along the usual lines: anecdotes from the kids, updates on school, apologies for not getting the laundry done, phone calls from doctors, a brief remark about the water bill being too high again.

The whole time, though, Hannah seemed to have something on her mind.

They had one glass of wine, and Mike started to cork the bottle, assuming that Hannah would not want another. “Wait a minute,” she said. “I’m not on until two.” She held her glass out toward him.

He obliged, filling the glass a little higher than warranted, because even though he assumed Hannah would be dropping off to sleep soon, there was no point not trying.

She took a sip, saying “mm,” in the middle of it, as though she had just remembered something very important. She wiped her lip with one finger, and straightened up. “One eventful thing *did* happen, though.”

Mike’s heart accelerated. He wasn’t sure why: there was no reason for this piece of news to be particularly exciting. Hannah almost always introduced things this way, and then disappointed, because what was “exciting” for normal people was just Hannah’s ordinary day.

Mike looked at her over his wine glass. *Go ahead.*

“This guy had a full-on heart attack at the zoo, went into arrest, and me and this other guy got him back. Crazy, right? The kid was a firefighter or something, and this guy was standing right next to both of us when he went down. Got him back before the paramedics were on scene and everything.”

Mike’s eyes widened. “No shit,” he said. The words *firefighter* and *guy* and *kid* grew loud in his memory. “You gonna get a lightning bolt for that?”

Hannah shrugged. She had so many she couldn’t keep track of them anymore. “We should.”

Mike’s brow furrowed at Hannah’s noncommittal answer, the pronoun *we*, and the odd feeling he was getting as *firefighter* and *guy* played even louder in his head.

“You sound like a coupla real heroes,” he said.

Hannah was staring into her wine glass. “Just lucky, I guess,” she mused. Her eyes jerked up to Mike’s face. “The guy, I mean. People these days. There were ten people standing there and half of them were still on their phones taking selfies through the whole thing. Don’t have a heart attack at the zoo, I guess.”

She pushed her hair from her forehead, still looking absent-mindedly into the wine. There was a pause – short, but too long for the moment – and then Mike said: “Unless you’re between a hot paramedic and a hot firefighter.”

This was the kind of joke Hannah almost always jumped on. It took her a few seconds to even register that he had spoken, and when she responded it was with a puff of exhaled breath. “Yeah. Right?”

She downed the remainder of the wine. “I’m pooped. I’m going to get up early tomorrow and do...” she waved behind her, her wrist slightly floppy, her speech taking on a slight slur (Hannah was not especially drunk, but her speech was the very first thing to go when she’d had too much, not drunk-in-an-alley slurred but ever-so-lispy) “...this.”

She was referring to the broken Exersaucer, the suitcase, the laundry, the mess.

As if on cue, the mountain of coats, which had been slowly tipping toward them for the entire conversation, reached the point of no return and came crashing to the floor.

Hannah was leaning on the counter with one elbow. She looked at the coats, and then turned to Mike. “Well,” she said calmly. “Goodnight.”

Mike came around the counter, in the back of his mind still hoping to lure her to bed with him, even though he knew the chances were slim to none. He put his arms around her, and brought his mouth down to meet hers, and they kissed. Her lips were cool from the wine, soft and wet. A vague airplane scent lingered on her hair, mixed with something she never wore. She hugged him tightly, and her mouth moved against his. Something a little bit more than a perfunctory kiss.

He felt his cock stirring, started to move his hands down, over her small frame, solid and fit.

But Hannah pulled away, smiled at him, and stepped down in a graceful swoop to fish her handbag from underneath the coats. “I’m not even going to *try* to fix this thing right now,” she said. “Man. That really went to my head.” She looked at Mike. “You staying up?”

And that was how things often ended, so Mike started to shrug.

But Hannah added, sexily, if not a bit drunkenly, “Or are you coming with me?”

Whether it was strange or not, no one needed to “suggest” something twice to Mike. He practically lunged at Hannah, pushing her backward toward the living room and hallway to the master bedroom with an adolescent, primal shove that almost sent them tumbling to the floor.

To his surprise, this only made Hannah smile, and clutch his shirt in her fingers, pulling him closer to her. They kissed and stumbled down the hallway, something they probably hadn’t done for years.

Hannah turned him around when they reached the master bedroom, and pushed him toward the bed, closing the door behind her with her foot.

Mike was already headed back to her, wondering what had gotten into her besides just wine. But there wasn’t much room in his mind for thinking about it, not once he touched her skin again. He worked his fingers with hers beneath the light cotton shirt she was wearing.

Her skin was slightly damp with sweat, perhaps a little left over from overheating in the car underneath the slicker, but her skin was hot with excitement as well. His fingers slid easily over the faint sheen of sweat, and the smell of her body came alive in his nostrils: lavender shampoo, the

sweet scent of her sweat, the slightly citrus flavor of something she used that he could never identify.

Melting into her body, pushing her against the door, he wondered why they didn't do this more often. Why did he let himself be discouraged from pursuing this pleasure more often: the heavy feel of her small breasts against his chest, her sweet lips under his, the promise of her tangy pussy in his mouth and closed around his cock?

The sweater came away from her skin with a peculiar amount of static crinkling at the top. A small shock electrified his chest, making Hannah smile beneath his lips. "Sorry," she said.

Her own hands were busy peeling away his clothes, unbuttoning his shirt and moving over his chest. She plunged a hand into his pants, not bothering to unbutton them, and her fingertips brushed over his hard cock and made him shiver.

Another smile from Hannah's mouth, her tongue busy in his, her reactions unusually hungry.

He pushed her stretchy gray pants down, then worked his hand back up to get to her panties. The back of his hand touched the center of the satin underwear, and he was surprised that the material was wet. Hannah was so rarely this excited, especially at this point in the game...

But he had no time to ponder that, or what it could mean, or even that particular aspect of his good fortune, because Hannah's hair seemed to stand straight up on end, and a moment of confusion made his thoughts freeze. He realized that she was sliding down the door, down to her knees, her eyes on his cock, her hand unbuttoning him, taking him out.

He literally could not have estimated for a million dollars the last time Hannah had given him a blowjob, so his first reaction was to simply stare at whatever it was that was unfolding before his eyes.

When she took him into her mouth, and the wet heat of her lips closed around the crown of his cock, her tongue darting over his tender flesh inside her hot orifice, he had to close his eyes and tip his head back. His hand dropped to her head, just to brace himself, as she took him deeper into her throat, her tongue inside her mouth making swirls and licks from within the fleshy pool of her hot saliva.

He looked down. She had grasped his cock at the base in her left hand, and for once she was wearing her wedding band – she took it off for work – with a simple diamond laid deep into the metal. He balled her hair

up in a fist and pushed her back toward the door, trying to free himself, and Hannah gave a slurpy, filthy gasp, her tongue trying to lick him when he withdrew from her mouth. A bead of pre-cum welled up on his crown and she leaned toward it, lapping it up with the point of her tongue.

He was going to come if this kept up, and he wanted to drag it out at least a little more. He pushed her back and used one hand to urge her up by the shoulder. Then he turned them both, backing her toward the bed, her mouth hot on his again, a vague heady taste of cock in her mouth.

It was then that the thought intruded: the taste of cock on his wife's lips.

What if it wasn't his?

His dick throbbed against her thigh as she shimmied out of her clothes, including her underwear, which now were completely soaked. A streak of her excitement ran down her thigh when she finally freed herself from the panties.

He pushed her onto the bed, the thought about her cock-tainted mouth pinging around in his head, his own cock throbbing mercilessly. He began at her knee, on the inside of her thigh, and drew his tongue from there along her inner thigh. Halfway up he caught the tangy, sweet taste of her pussy juices on her skin, dragged along her thigh when she took off her soaked underwear.

He looked up at her as she curled her fingers in his hair and pushed his mouth into the center of her legs. Usually, Hannah let him playfully flick at her clit, explore her folds, work her up to his lapping at her. Tonight, she pushed him into the soaked folds of her silky cunt and he could barely distinguish what was what as she pushed him deep into her wet flesh.

Her clit was hard and swollen, darting away from his tongue as he tried to place the blade on it and massage her. She pushed against the back of his head and he sank in deeper, his chin and cheeks getting wet, her hips grinding up against him.

She rocked against his face to make herself come, her eyes aimed at the ceiling and then closed. Her mouth hung open, she gasped, and then she screamed. Her pussy welled up with more sweet juice, which he greedily sloshed about in with his tongue, looking up at her heaving chest, her strained neck, the pulsing of blood in her arteries.

Her hand relaxed and he raised himself up, pushing her back on the bed, grasping her legs and lifting them to his shoulders. Hannah was still

enjoying the waves of her orgasm, and she was limp and doll-like as he manipulated her, for the first time in such a long time, into a sort of obscene position: legs spread and resting on his shoulders, ass tilted up. Bending forward, he made her knees bend and her legs spread wider, as he admired the sight of her engorged and glistening pussy, the light blonde hair that she kept neatly trimmed barely visible, her clit pulsing in pleasure.

He sank into her, and she twisted and gasped. Her clit was still sensitive, and her legs still trembling. He often wondered if Hannah faked her orgasms, but this one was so wet, and her eyes were so glassy, and her legs trembling with such minute shakes, that he knew it was real. He sank in until he was fully sheathed, and let her shudder beneath him again.

He started to fuck her, and had to grip the sheets and try to think of something else to keep himself from spilling inside of her then and there. But it wasn't long before she began to rise up to meet his thrusts, excited again.

She dropped her legs to the small of his back, crossing them at the ankles and pushing her heels against him, driving him deep inside of her while she pulled herself up to his chest and clung to him.

They fucked like this – passionately, both of them absorbed in their carnal pleasure, for only a few minutes, and then he felt her legs tighten around his waist and her heels dig painfully into his back.

She came again, her pussy another explosion of juices, and he let himself go, filling her with his cum.

Just before he came, he caught the tiniest whiff of musky scent on her lips, and the image of her mouth filled with another man's cock whipped through his mind. He came hard, filling his wife with his seed, and collapsed on top of her.

Hannah pushed him to her side, holding him against her shoulder. Her bra was still on, and he played with the lace, his fingers digging deeper to reach her aureole, until Hannah's hand lazily rose and stopped him. "That tickles," she said.

Which was a much more common thing for Hannah to do or say.

She wiped her forehead.

"That was something," he said, in the most joking tone he could muster.

Hannah laughed lightly. "Seriously."

He waited. He was desperate to ask her what had gotten into her, why she was so wet, if she had, in fact, been thinking of another man's cock while she had his in her mouth... and what had inspired her to suck on his dick, anyway...

But he didn't want to say the wrong thing. By the time he settled on: "What got into *you*?" in a pitch-perfect tone of camaraderie and complicity...

Hannah's eyes were closed heavily, and she murmured something he couldn't understand.

And that was that.

CHAPTER 2

Mike rolled over in the morning, his fingers seeking the warmth of Hannah's body. The heaviness of a good sleep made his limbs move thickly.

The sheets were cold. His eyes flew open, checking to see that he was not caught up in that half-woken confusion of the early morning, when dreams seep into reality. His wife had come home, hadn't she? And they had made love, for the first time in ages, and it had been incredibly hot. Right?

An imprint of Hannah's body remained in the memory foam, and the sheets were strewn carelessly. A squeal and a crash from the hallway, followed by Hannah's voice admonishing one of the children for running in the house, confirmed that the previous night had not been a dream.

Nor had the last nine years, of children and hand-washing, arguments about how to load the dishwasher, fold laundry, and plan for retirement, nor the nine years of early mornings that almost always included the destruction of something in their home.

"... not to do that. How many times do I have to say it?"

Mike rose and tossed off the covers. Footsteps sounded in the hallway.

He hurried to put on a pair of boxers as Jake and Ella came padding in.

"Mom says I can stay over at Jessie's if it's okay with you," Jake began. "And I'm also supposed to tell you to get some more milk."

"Because he spilled it," Ella offered. She was in a tattle-tale phase that everyone hoped would end sooner rather than later.

"Shut up!" Jake said to Ella, but as usual, plowed ahead with his own business. He turned to his dad. "So can I?"

Mike ran his fingers through his hair. "On a school night? Mom said you could? I gotta run that -"

"Kids. Get in the kitchen and eat the fancy breakfast I made for you, and Jake, you're twisting the agreement a little, I said ask your father, not yes as long as it's okay with him."

Jake groaned. Hannah stepped through their retreating forms, smiling, with a steaming cup in her hand. "Not the same thing, bro."

“Roasted,” Ella contributed.

“Shut *up*, God you’re so stupid,” Jake said.

Their voices disappeared into the kitchen.

Hannah had a lovely glow, her hair was loose around her shoulders, and she was wearing an inside-out camisole and a pair of tight-fitting, thin-knit sweats that accentuated her sporty figure: small, pert breasts, toned stomach, and slender but well-rounded thighs beneath a well-turned bottom that looked model-perfect from the side. “It’s soooo good to be home,” she said wryly, and set the mug on the night table next to Mike.

She peeled the camisole off, and Mike admired her bared breasts, the smoothness of her abdomen – she had the torso of a climber, or a dancer, showing no muscle beneath her flesh but strong as steel. A smattering of five tiny moles, each one successively smaller than the last, formed a crescent leading out of her oval belly-button. When she wore swimsuits people sometimes asked if it was a tattoo.

Mike reached for her knee, planning to pull her to him. The sight of her caramel-colored nipples in her small, perfectly round aureole, had stirred his semi-hard cock to full strength.

Hannah twisted easily from his grasp, turning the shirt right-side-out with the practiced hand of a woman who had folded trillions of pounds of laundry, and had it back on in a jiffy. “No time for that, cowboy. You have to get to work, I have to pack lunches, and I’m sure there will be some broken glass to pick up in about three...two....one....”

Hannah stood with her hand on her hip, her head cocked, her green eyes twinkling, and they both paused to listen down the hall.

“Huh,” she said. “It’s a miracle.”

She was already striding out of the bedroom.

Mike rubbed his hair again, tried to put his erection out of his mind.

“Oh God,” he muttered.

Another day like all the other days.

He padded to the bathroom and turned on the shower.

He loved his family, loved their life, and he’d be the first to say, “don’t get me wrong, I love those guys, but...”

But.

It would be nice, for just once, to be able to fuck his wife in the morning before the hurricane of banalities whipped through.

As he closed the door to the shower, he heard Hannah's voice, in full-on mom tone, loud over the water.

Sounded like she wasn't far off the mark about that broken glass.

He leaned one arm against the shower tile. Memories of the night before were keeping him... alert. He found himself stroking his cock, thinking of Hannah, how wet her pussy had been, how eagerly she had indulged him, how strange it had all been.

The warm glow of the night before, as all good things tended to do with him, took on a darkened edge. *Why* had Hannah been so turned on? What was she thinking of, with her mouth hot on his shoulder, her eyes closed, her heels digging into his back? Was it him, or someone else?

Thoughts like those had the curious effect of sinking through him, from his heart to his groin, cool and erotic. He came within seconds, his mouth open, annoyed suddenly by water that was splashing from his shoulder into his eyes, which he hadn't noticed at all while masturbating, thinking of all the unfaithful thoughts that could be in Hannah's mind.

He wasn't sure when the edgy fantasies had begun. He'd always been a little dark when it came to women, his mind always willing to take a detour from reality to obscure fantasies. He wasn't sure what the thrill was, but it plucked at something inside of him, threw his heart up into his mouth and his cock into high gear, thinking about his girlfriends kissing him goodnight and then sneaking off into the shadows to fuck some other guy. It was like picking a scab, pushing on inflamed gums, scraping away at something both itchy and painful... it satisfied a need at the same time that it hurt.

The inclination had disappeared when he and Hannah got married, maybe because he was so swept up in love with her. She was fiery, assertive, strong, and outdoorsy. Calm as an icy lake in the face of emergencies and danger, wry and witty in the face of almost everything else. Incredibly kind, but in the sort of way that broadcast she was not going to take any shit.

Her face was cute, not beautiful: unusually green eyes, emerald in color and unflecked by a spot of brown, her very blonde hair, an upturned nose, pink lips in no particularly lovely shape: but it all came together.

Dark, pretty moles in lovely shapes were there to discover on her body. An unraised brown beauty mark high on her left cheek marred an

otherwise perfect complexion, a small one on her neck led to another on her shoulder, like stepping stones they led down her back to her bottom, where there were none. The crescent of moles, slightly raised, could be read like Braille around her navel.

They'd moved in together, gone hiking and climbing and camping, far more than Mike had wanted to, but he enjoyed watching Hannah chop up wood like a lumberjack, start campfires in seconds, fly-fish like a pro. He had loved how she had lifted an arm sleepily and waved at the air, nonchalant and calm as ice, when he had tapped her in the middle of the night to tell her he thought there was a bear in the campsite.

"He'll go away," she had said, and hadn't even opened her eyes when their tin plates and cups went clattering to the ground, nor when the bear had been sniffing right next to her head through the tent. When the bear left she had opened her eyes and giggled.

With a girl like that, there was hardly any room to think that anything could go wrong, no reason to believe it. He didn't have his usual thoughts, creeping into his mind and working their bizarre magic on him.

Until Hannah got pregnant. She declared it matter-of-factly, which was something Hannah was good at doing: she was a paramedic, after all, she told three or four people a day that someone had died. "I'm pregnant," she had told him. "We should get married."

Which had been fine by him: it was what he wanted. He had been working up the nerve to ask her, fearing the devastation of her saying no. That was erased with her "proposal." She didn't want a big wedding, she didn't have any kind of crisis about having kids. He had always wanted a family, and now he had one, with the most amazing girl in the world.

But from that moment on, the dark thoughts started sprouting like a Chia Pet, which he, not Hannah, was old enough to remember. He didn't suspect Hannah of anything – she didn't have time to have an affair.

Unless it was with someone she worked with, his mind would say.

His dark thoughts made him feel guilty, maybe most of all because, while he told himself they were purely fantasy (he didn't really *want* Hannah to sleep with another guy; he didn't really *want* Hannah to be a mean, treacherous, unfaithful wife), there was a part of him, deep down inside, that thought he maybe really *did* want that.

That was the part of him that he tried to keep buried inside, as deep as he could. The part of him that made his cock get hard when Hannah came

home later than he thought she should from a shift, her cheeks flushed, her eyes twinkling. The part of him that simmered, thinking about all of the things she could have been doing with some very hot, 25-year old hunk she'd been assigned to mentor, as they waited at their base station for a call. Sometimes they were assigned to be on standby at a fire, just in case any of the firefighters needed rescuing.

But it was never that. She had delivered a baby, or helped talk someone down from a ledge, or one of her "regulars" - old ladies who called the paramedics complaining of chest pain just to fill their houses with company - had lost her pillbox and Hannah had helped her find it.

Hannah was a good wife. A loyal wife. She didn't even have the personality for cheating; she was a get-the-job-done kind of girl. If she had thought she wanted to kick Mike to the curb, she'd say so, just the way she told people their loved ones were dead or had told Mike she was pregnant and they were getting married.

Mike, she would say. I'm sick of you, and we're getting a divorce.

That didn't stop Mike from fantasizing. Or diving into the very dark recesses of the Internet, where evidently there were men as dark as him or darker. He began with videos, like any man would, but they weren't as erotic to him as most porn usually was. It didn't thrill him to see someone else's wife fucking some other guy. The *idea* thrilled him, the idea of his own wife.

For a while, when the kids were very young and Hannah was either working or sleeping or caring for the kids, and they didn't have sex at all, and he knew it was very wrong to be even thinking such things, Mike went on internet forums. They were more titillating than the porn. Listening to the stories of real live people with real life wives cheating on them, or real life wives who willingly had sex with other men right in front of their husbands, got him hard as a rock.

He had a real addiction for a while.

But they had gotten back into the swing of things, the kids were older, they had more time together. The fantasy submerged itself as soon as they started having sex more regularly. If you called once a week or maybe every two weeks, or who can even keep track of it, frequent. Still, his urges had dulled, like everything else in his life.

But Hannah's trip had reignited his fantasy.

He left for work reluctantly. If it were any other day, he could have gone in late, stayed home with Hannah to try and get one more round in with her.

She kissed him with more passion than usual, more than a drive-by peck. She stopped to put her arms on his shoulders. She purred in his mouth. “Sure you can’t stay?”

His chest was actually tight as he sighed. “I can’t,” he said, disappointment dripping from his throat. He had about twenty clients headed to the clinic in the morning, a lot of them emergencies he’d booked yesterday.

Hannah smiled. “Okay,” she said. Hannah loved animals, sometimes it seemed more than she did people – or maybe she just couldn’t leave the valves of empathy open for people in her job. She would never stand in the way of Mike getting to work on time to save a dog or a cat, which he wasn’t going to tell her was about 1% of his job, the rest being euthanasia and rabies vaccinations.

“I wanted to go on a run anyway,” she said, looking over her shoulder as she walked away, her ass perfect in her gray leggings.

Your loss, her face seemed to say.

As if on cue, the phone in his pocket rang, and sure enough, it was Missy Gingrich, his assistant and receptionist, 90 pounds of red-haired, frantic, fury. But one hell of an employee.

“Can you pick up those meds on your way in, or do you need me to go and get them.”

Missy did not ask questions. She yelled statements.

“I got it,” Mike said.

“Your first appointment is in one hour,” Missy said. “Tell me you are on the road.”

“I am on the road.”

Hannah’s laugh tinkled down the hallway. She liked Missy. Her assessment: “She gets shit done.” Hannah always liked people like that.

(Hannah did avoid Missy when it was Girl Scout cookie season, though. Missy’s sales pitch was to put you down for ten boxes and tell you about it as she was tossing them at your head and informing you that you owed her daughter twenty-five bucks).

“Good.”

Missy hung up, because she wasn't big on goodbyes, either. If you wanted sweet-talking, you had to be paying for a visit.

"I'm out," Mike called.

"You're on the road," Hannah called back.

He stood in the kitchen, rocking slightly on his feet. Hannah would be in the bedroom, peeling away that camisole, right now. His groin stirred, he rocked back on his heels, looking at his phone.

And that's when the home phone startled the hell out of him.

They were probably one of the last people on earth with a landline, at Hannah's insistence, because "people who only have a cell phone are idiots." This was in reference to emergency services, who were unlikely to have time to follow up on all the cell phone 911 hangups they received in a day.

She would know. It was worth \$85 a month to not fight it.

The phone hadn't rung in years, to his knowledge. It was an old-school wall phone, with a cord and everything. He leaned to the side, more out of curiosity than anything, and picked it up.

"Hello?"

"Hi... Mr.... Moore, is it?"

Mike was caught off-guard. Hannah had never changed her last name, so it was common for solicitors to ask for Mrs. Peterson, but not Mr. Moore.

The woman filled the silence readily. "My name is Kristina Gray, I'm with Upstate Online, we're an online human interest magazine... *are* you Mr. Moore? Are you married to Hannah Moore?"

Mike found his voice. His brain was a little addled, but he knew he didn't like solicitations.

"Yeah, we're not interested in any subscription right now," he began.

"Oh sir, sorry, no, I'm not calling about that. I was hoping to speak to Hannah Moore, actually. Is she there?"

Mike looked at the hallway. He started to walk, and was yanked back by the antediluvian phone cord. "Uh," he said. "I, uh... she's, why did you want to talk to her?"

"Are you Mr. Moore, sir? Are you her husband?"

The person's voice was greedy. Scammy. Something salacious tinged it.

"What were you calling about?" he said gruffly.

“Pardon me, Mr. Moore. I didn't properly introduce myself. My name is Kristina and I'm a *journalist*. I'm actually following up with Hannah about an incident on Denver flight-”

Mike laughed lightly. “I'm sorry,” he said, piecing it all together. He heard “Denver,” and jumped quickly to the life-saving event. “I, yeah, of course, the zoo thing. Let me see if she's just – oh, here she is.”

He handed the phone to Hannah, who was walking toward him with eyebrows arched, changed already into her running gear, a bright orange shirt made her look like a sexy safety vest with her clashing blonde hair, and a pair of very hot black running shorts that barely made it to mid-thigh.

“Who is it?” she mouthed.

“Some press thing, about Denver,” he said.

Hannah rolled her eyes. “Tell her she's gotta talk to my -” she cut herself off from the standard line and reached for the phone, remembering, Mike guessed, that she had saved the guy while she was off-duty.

She cradled the phone against her shoulder and put her hands on the wall to stretch her calves by stepping backward. “This is Hannah Moore,” she said.

Mike slipped a hand over her taut right buttock, and Hannah gave him a sideways look while the woman's voice chattered away in the earpiece.

Mike was so busy admiring her bottom, and the feel of it in his hand – heavy with toned muscle, spherical, so close to that triangle of downy yellow hair. He didn't notice Hannah's face pale for a moment. Her body stiffened. She stopped stretching and stood up, back straight, erect.

Cold-as-ice Hannah was not cold-as-ice. It only lasted a moment, but it made Mike's scalp crawl. She faced the blank wall, green eyes moving quickly back and forth. Her chest rose and fell. Her lips pursed.

Mike could see her heart rate – normally a steady 60 beats a minute like a metronome, 120 when she was jogging, nothing in between, even if blood was spraying out of someone's artery – pulsed erratically in her throat.

Her eyes flew to Mike's face, the color of her skin ashen for just a moment.

Then her green eyes got dark, her pupils consuming the irises.

She sucked her breath in fast.

Her heart rate steadied.

Mike raised his eyebrows, her concern, so unusual, contagious. He could feel his pulse racing.

His first thoughts went to some kind of legal liability. Saving people's lives when you were off-duty was a weirdly contentious thing. You had to do it in some states, you couldn't do it in others, you might get sued in yet others. He thought of his business, the legal exposures, the fact that they had never gotten a lawyer to fully protect his clinic from a situation like this.

Hannah shook her head slightly and held up a finger.

It was under control. She was back under control.

"I apologize," she said politely. "I prefer not to make a comment about that incident, and I would appreciate you not publishing anything about it."

There was a pause while the woman chattered away.

"This is the first I've heard about it," Hannah said, turning away from Mike. "And I -"

There was a deafening pause. The woman's voice had gotten louder, almost intelligible. Hannah repeated, steely cool: "I have no comment."

And then she hung up.

There was a very uncomfortable moment, as she stood, staring at the phone. "How did those twits even get this number?" she marveled.

"What is it? What did she want?"

Hannah sucked her lower lip in, her eyes moving as she thought.

"Hannah?"

She turned to him, still thinking. When she looked up at him, she had on her emergency-services face. It was a mask of calm, confident and assertive. "Oh, that's the press, about that thing in Denver, something about... I don't even know what. It's fine, nothing's wrong. I just don't understand how they got... my number..." Her eyes shifted, looking through him. Beneath her calm exterior, she held a secret.

Mike was still thinking about his business. "We're not... there's no exposure for us about that or anything?"

Hannah seemed grateful for the question. She shook herself slightly, a sharp inhale that made her nostrils inexplicably flare. Her chest rose and fell as she smiled and put a hand on his shoulder. "Oh it's nothing like that."

"Then wha-?" Mike started to ask, but Hannah was already talking.

"I don't even know why they're interested, really."

She started to stretch again. “Small-town papers, man.”

Her muscles were tight, her eyes moving fast. Something lurked in her thoughts.

She turned to Mike, who was still standing there, his mind moving slower than hers, dark thoughts only just now rising up from the cracks. But his dark thoughts came to him like tar seeping through the floor, and Hannah’s mind worked like the autonomic nervous system. She looked him up and down. “What are you *doing*?” she asked him. “Missy is going to lose her shit.”

“Right,” he said, snapping out of it. He fished the keys from his blazer. “But everything is -”

Hannah leaned in for a quick kiss. “It’s fine. It’s just bullshit. Go. Go save dogs and cats.”

He went, because in case you’ve never been bossed around by someone who’s been a first responder for twelve years, that’s what you do when those people tell you to do something.

But the tar was welling up.

*

He had plenty of time to think about it in the car. Plenty of time for the black thoughts to ooze through, filling the basement of his mind.

They had moved outside of the city, to a small town that was about an hour and a half from the city center, to enjoy country living. The idea had been for him to open a practice another half hour out, in a town called Milton. Hannah had a lot of seniority, was an advanced paramedic, and the stations in rural areas desperately needed paramedics, so it had been a simple matter for her to get on at a station about forty-five minutes away. It served a large swath of small towns that had been partially swallowed up by the ever-growing metropolitan area.

What had happened was that Mike spent a lot of time driving. They had yet to locate an ideal practice nearby, and now that his practice was growing so much in Wilson Heights, a city suburb, he was reluctant to leave the money behind. They loved the country-ish life they led, even though the city was so close by.

Wilson Heights was an hour away on a good day, but the traffic was jammed on a two-lane highway that took him straight into the suburbs from

the center of their small town, Redville.

The conversation between his wife and Kristina of the Upstate gossip rag replayed and replayed in his mind as he inhaled diesel fumes and inched forward in the traffic.

Hannah was unflappable. She didn't get pale, or start breathing fast. Ella had once actually started choking and turning blue, and Hannah had Heimlich'd her like she was folding laundry.

Hannah also did not cuss in everyday situations, and she had done it twice after getting off the phone. Shit, *and* bullshit.

Hannah also did not cuss in emergency situations, because it was her job not to.

So what was it that had turned Hannah's face pale, set her eyes to moving rapidly, drained her thoughts out of the room and to another place?

The first idea he'd had, of some kind of legal ramification for having saved the guy's life, no longer rang true to him. From Hannah's telling, all she'd done was CPR.

With a firefighter.

Together.

His mind started to wander, circling in on something. The reporter's voice when she had asked, are you *Mr. Moore*?

The phone rang, startling him out of his reverie.

"Tell me you're almost here."

Missy did not wait for him to say hello, which was nothing new.

"There's a backup on sixty-one," he said.

Missy sighed into the phone. "How long."

"I should be there in about.. I don't know, Missy," he sighed, suddenly and uncharacteristically losing patience. He pushed his hair from his forehead. "I'll get there when I get there."

"I'm shuffling your first appointments."

Mike gripped the steering wheel and said nothing. As he expected, Missy had hung up.

Where had he been in his thoughts?

Are you Mister Moore?

Mike narrowed his eyes.

What could have happened to make his wife grow pale, but also involve the mysterious firefighter, and also be cruelly sexy? The string

between his heart and his groin grew icicles on it, tugged coldly at his cock, sent a ripple of pleasure straight to his skin.

The traffic edged forward, and then suddenly, inexplicably, opened up.

CHAPTER 3

Hannah let the garage door close on her husband, her blood pounding in her ears.

Stop.

Assess.

A thump from upstairs, followed by the fledgling pubescent low-voice of Jake, and a whining wail from Ella, reminded her that she had kids to get out the door.

Do that first.

She tunnel-visioned her way into lunch-making, packing, chasing down of cross-country attire, final checks on the flurry of paperwork that seemed to come home with each of them. She was grateful for the focus, grateful to have everything else crowded out of her mind.

They were off to the road to wait for the bus, bickering so loudly she could hear them all the way to the end of the driveway.

Then her predicament came over her in waves.

The reporter's – a reporter? Seriously? - voice came to her in chunks, a collage of crazy questions, all of them sounding very, very bad, or wrong, or like she had *done* something wrong.

I just want to let you know ahead of time I'm recording this conversation. It's standard practice to make sure I don't make a mistake.

I'm calling to see if I could arrange an interview with you about your relationship with August Healy. Was that your husband I was just speaking to?

There's a Twitter thread all about it, Mrs. Moore. Perhaps you want to give me your email address so you can take a look at it and then I can follow up with a few questions for you...

"Okay," she said, pressing herself against the front door.

She needed to think. She needed a plan.

What the hell was even going on?

"Okay," she repeated, walking swiftly and with purpose to her laptop. Or, at least, it would have been with purpose if she had known immediately where it was. She found it, the charge dead, on a teetering pile of papers in

a room that could easily be dubbed an office, a junk closet, a guest bedroom, or a laundry depot.

The power cord was another matter. She finally located it in the basement.

Twitter, Twitter, Twitter. How did one even go about looking for something on Twitter that they didn't know existed? She marveled at how surreal it was to be looking for herself on the platform she barely understood or cared about.

But she had to find it. She closed her eyes and strained her brain... what had the reporter said? In the final, shrill moments before Hannah had hung up, the reporter had chucked a ton of information at her: contact numbers, email, the name of the magazine, an assurance that she would pick up her call day or night...

But what had the Twitter thing been about?

Hannah searched with futility for her name, August's name, a few other hashtags that led her nowhere, and then finally, had the intelligent idea to look online at the magazine, Upstate Whatever-It-Was.

It was a cheap, gossipy-looking online magazine, which reassured her a little bit. And in its confusing labyrinth of celebrity gossip and fluff stories, Hannah could find nothing about herself.

She closed her laptop. "Okay," she told herself.

What did she know? Something was somewhere on Twitter about her and August Healy, enough to get the attention of some crappy online gossip rag to call her and want an interview.

But what would it *be*?

It was true she had sat next to him on the plane.

Her chest grew hot, the flush traveling to her neck, along her throat, thinking about sitting next to him. She had spent a lot of time staring at the muscles on his arms.

He was cocky. She had rolled her eyes a lot at him, but there was no denying she found him attractive. No denying that her body responded to him, in a raw, physical form. No doubt that a hundred *ideas* had crossed her mind – and they made her blush right there in her living room, thinking about them.

But what would anyone have *seen* to put on Twitter?

She hadn't touched him. Once, her hand had brushed over his forearm, and his thigh had been against hers all through the flight because

he was a large, muscular man who sat with his legs slightly spread, probably to accommodate his very good-sized cock (if the shape of it under his jeans was any indication).

But they hadn't actually *done* any of the things she'd thought of doing. So what was it then, that the internet saw?

Her back ached. She had spent the whole morning bent over her laptop on the living room floor, because of the easy access to an outlet. Her eyes were blurry, she had no way of knowing what was going on.

She could call him. Maybe August Healy knew what was going on.

Her fingers played with the clip of the laptop, and then she shook her head, stood up abruptly, and walked with purpose back to the master bedroom.

She needed to go on a run.

*

The day was chaos right from the start, a blur of dogs who had eaten bags of shit on the side of the road, ear infections, lethargic cats, two euthanizations, a Cocker Spaniel whose skin had swelled up into a brain-like web of lumps from a wasp sting. A German Shepherd puppy who was high as a kite, to the relief of his owner, who had, with the help of the internet, diagnosed the dog with a fatal neurological condition Mike was unsure even existed.

The fucking internet.

Missy kept them coming, and going, her thin features and brown eyes set in determination. Missy was not changing any more appointments, and she was going to squeeze in every single emergency whether Mike ate lunch or not.

It was good, it took his mind off the black tar that was oozing into his thoughts from every direction.

At last, around four o'clock, thanks to Missy's wild efficiency, they had cleared everyone out, someone had canceled, and Mike had a moment to put his feet up and eat a sandwich on a small porch at the back of the clinic, which had once been a residential house. He was so hungry and spaced out, preoccupied with a few of the charts he'd filled out in too much of a hurry, that he barely thought of the morning at all. The tar was still there, lurking around in his mind, filling his head with its vapor – appealing

and toxic at the same time – but he didn't have time to crawl into it, really wrap himself up in it.

That all changed when he strode back into the office, and found that whatever had afflicted his wife this morning had evidently been contagious.

The unflappable Missy Steinbeck was glued to the blue glare of her computer screen, a pallor creeping slowly over her face, while a customer, yapping Dachshund in tow, *waited*.

"Missy," Mike said. His voice was more annoyed than usual, but certainly not enough to make Missy jump like she did. She looked up at him, startled, her face almost horrified, snapped her open mouth shut, and followed his gesture to the woman waiting at the reception desk.

"I..." she said, her mouth open again as though it had come off its hinges. The color of the screen changed as she clicked the mouse, minimizing the window that had so horrified her. She straightened herself up in her chair, smoothed her hair, and cleared her throat. "I apologize. Mrs. Cleary. Jackson is here for his regular checkup?"

Missy *was* capable of using question-intonation, but it was reserved for customers. She gave Mike a weird look as she showed Jackson the dog and Mrs. Cleary to an examination room.

"What's up?" Mike asked her. "You look like you've seen a ghost."

His first thought was that something very exciting was happening in the news cycle, but Missy wasn't a news-cycle type of gal, unless it involved celebrity gossip.

Her jaw fell open a little bit yet again. "Um," she said, but it sounded more like "up."

The phone rang. Missy pointed at reception over her shoulder. "Gotta get that."

Mike went to take care of Jackson.

The day ended at five. Missy was whispering into the phone during one break in the constant flow of clients, and hung up after casting a guilty look in Mike's direction.

Likely, it was just Missy taking a celebrity gossip situation personally, Mike thought.

Still, it *was* weird.

He was conflating things, he decided at 4:45. His fantasies, his wife, the strange phone call, his fantasies, his dark thoughts, his fantasies, and of

all people, Missy, who had as little to do with any of that as Kim Kardashian.

Well...

...as little to do with all that as Jackson the dog.

He strode out to reception at five, and started shuffling some files.

“That’s it?” he asked.

Missy nodded, her eyes glued to her screen. The light flickered as she minimized another screen.

Mike closed a folder and handed it to her. “Dish it,” he said. As much as he hated Missy’s celebrity gossip, he really wanted her to stay at his practice, and he figured she would migrate to another office if he didn’t listen to this drivel once in a while.

Missy looked at him blankly, and the same white pallor appeared on her face, moving down from her forehead. “Uh... what.”

He leaned on the counter and waved at the screen. “Whatever it is, on the world wide web there, that has you so captivated.”

This ordinarily made Missy crack a smile, him calling it the “world wide web.” He was just too old to be as dialed in as Missy was, and he often said things like “ChatSnap,” to her endless amusement.

“Um,” Missy said. She leaned on her elbows and folded her arms. “I mean...” she looked back at the screen, which was displaying nothing more than the desktop. She reached for the keyboard and pressed a key. “It’s not really... my place.... Anyway, it’s.... you know. This puts me in a bad position.”

Her voice was suddenly hostile, and she snapped some folders into alignment, pursing her lips as she did so.

Mike rubbed his forehead with the back of his hand. All this #MeToo bullshit, to be perfectly honest, made his heart accelerate any time any woman acted strangely around him. “Something wrong?” he asked patiently.

Please, dear Jesus, let there be nothing wrong.

Missy looked at him over the edge of her folders. “Um... okay... so, I mean... yeah. You know. I don’t really want to say anything. But... I mean, you don’t get on Twitter at all, do you?”

Mike could feel a fearful look creeping over his own face, though he couldn’t say why, exactly. What the hell was *wrong* with his normally straight-talking assistant?

“Twitter, Twitter,” he joked, trying to diffuse the feeling of horror that was coming over him for no apparent reason.

Missy not “feeling like it was her place” to say anything was a *red flag*. A really big red flag. Missy was pretty sure it was her place to say whatever she wanted to say, whenever she wanted to say it.

She chewed on her lower lip. It was in no way attractive when she did this. She sighed loudly.

“You know, it’s probably just a mistake,” she said finally.

“Missy, you’re driving me fucking crazy,” Mike said shortly. “What are you talking about?”

Missy took another deep breath, which Mike found even more horrifying.

Twitter, Twitter, a million things could go wrong on Twitter. *Was* he on Twitter? Had someone posted something about him?

Relief started to seep into his veins. *That* was it. Some bad Twitter post had taken off and made its way around among those users of the internet who could be bothered to care about Ryker Street Veterinary Services. He couldn’t remember a bad client interaction for months, but there were a lot of anti-vaccination wackos out there, it was probably that...

Missy blinked slowly. She leaned forward, and blasted a hole right through his relieving thoughts: “Did your wife just fly back here yesterday. On a plane.”

Statements, Missy-style. Not questions.

Mike couldn’t check his smart-ass at the door. “She flew, but on a hanglider. Why?”

Missy didn’t blink. She turned the screen of her computer slightly, so Mike could see it by leaning on the counter.

“Okay, it’s probably nothing, but there’s this whole thing about...” She typed and clicked as she was talking, distracted by the posts on the screen, scrolling, scrolling through the endless garbage of Twitter. “Where did...? Okay, here.”

She pointed at the screen.

Mike narrowed his eyes.

Twitter confused the fuck out of him, if he was perfectly honest.

All he could see of this “post” was a lot of disconnected jabber, hearts and hashtags, bouncing emoticons, some words actually written in the

English language, and a few poor-quality pictures of the inside of a plane and the back of people's heads.

A plane.

Well, what could have happened? Hannah lost her luggage and complained? It was possible. But Hannah was *not* a Twitter type. She maybe had a Facebook account and she'd lost the password about the same time she'd set it up, almost five years ago. There was one picture of her on it -

His heart stopped dead in his chest. Missy was scrolling, the words were filtering through to his mind, and the Facebook picture was among all the hearts and words and emoticons and hashtags flying at him...

#planebae2

...two hot people...

...RomCom gold...

...firefighter.... paramedic... coincidence...Denver...true love...

Hannah's Facebook picture.

Looks like I found her

#getthem2gether

There were very few times in his life that Mike would say that he had blacked out. All of them involved alcohol. But he was almost immediately sitting in the small closet-sized space he affectionately called an "office," staring at the walls, with no idea how he had gotten there.

His computer was on.

He blinked.

The sequence of events leading to him sitting in that chair slowly made their way to his consciousness.

He had shrugged, and then laughed, almost maniacally. "It's blown out of proportion," his mouth had said, taking over for him, almost like magic. "A reporter called about it this morning. Hannah didn't even know anything about it."

And then he had laughed again. "Twitter," he had added. Another shrug.

Crazy old Twitter, always blowing things out of proportion, making a story where there isn't one, making it look like your wife has a burgeoning romance with a VERY YOUNG firefighter when she doesn't. You know how Twitter is. Shrug.

He had tapped the spine of the folder on the counter. “Let’s wrap it up, Missy. Or, well, *you* wrap it up. I have to do a few files. But you go ahead and get home. Busy day tomorrow.”

Stop it, he had told himself. *Stop fucking talking*.

His mind was split into two parts – the out-of-control one, and the one doing all the talking and sounding, quite plausibly, normal. The one that had decided to play this off, like it wasn’t his wife or it wasn’t a big deal, even as the other part of his brain could barely keep up with what was happening.

The other part of his brain was completely drenched in tarry thoughts. Twitter hashtags loomed in his field of vision, the photographs, the curly blonde hair, the insinuations, the good-looking man facing his wife, smiling, at the entrance to a plane. The night before, Hannah’s wet, wet pussy, his fantasies, his fears... all of it swirling around directionlessly.

Missy had accepted – nominally – the cool attitude of the first part of his mind. “Oh,” she had said, half-disappointed, half-relieved. “Oh, good. Phew.” She had spun the screen around to face her.

And then, just as Mike had begun walking back to his office, she had added: “I really didn’t want to be the one to, you know, drop this on you. Like if you didn’t know about it. Aaaaaawk-ward.”

Now, he was in his office, frantically signing up for a Twitter account, because he’d long since forgotten the password to the first one he had.

It took another half hour, during which time Missy left, for him to find and decipher the Twitter feed related to his wife. His heart pounded as he sorted through it.

Evidently, the thread had started with a feed from a Twitter user named EverydayRomCom, who was a blogger. About romance. Everyday romantic comedy.

Evidently, this blogger had been on the plane when, surprise! The out-of-town, off-duty volunteer firefighter (*hot, hot, hot*, the Internet screamed) and off-duty paramedic who had resuscitated a man at the Denver Zoo the day before the flight *after pulling him back from almost tipping into the trench with the polar bears* (a detail, Mike noted, with a burn in his chest, that Hannah had neglected to mention). RomCom the blogger had seen the report on the news, and so wasn’t she surprised when she looked up from her first-class seat to see Mr. Firefighter walking down the aisle.

She had posted this development on Twitter:

“Just saw the *hot* firefighter from yesterday’s news story on my flight... too bad he’s in coach. Too late to change my seat? Or maybe he needs an upgrade?”

Link to news story, which Mike of course watched.

Standard human interest story, a short interview with the firefighter, August Healy. *Maybe* approaching thirty, a five-o’clock shadow of light brown hair on his square jaw, piercing blue eyes, a sort of Marlboro-man look without all the smoking. A tattoo on one arm that looked military, a gray t-shirt clinging to the perfect sculpture of his body. A pitch-perfect smile, a Midwestern accent, a hand through his gorgeous, GQ light brown hair.

“I just stepped in and did what anyone would do. The um... Hannah here really took over....”

The camera panned to Hannah, hair loose, eyes glittering, shy smile, nothing to say.

The reporter trying to recover for the two aw-shucks heroes: “The patient is recovering at Denver General, and his family extends their thanks to these two heroes.”

Anchor: “I suppose you can’t get any luckier than that.”

And then a nice shot of August Healy, volunteer firefighter and muscle man, all-American hero, and blonde, green-eyed Hannah. Shoulder to shoulder, smiling.

And then – a knife of pain, cold and sharp, plunged through Mike’s gut: August Healy and Hannah Moore turning to look at each other, smiling

-

The clip ended.

Mike began to dig further.

RomCom the blogger is shocked by the next development in her plane ride when:

“OMG! Change of plans, the supercute paramedic just got on the plane. People, do I see romantic adventure beginning or what?”

And of course, the Twitter universe agreed. The firefighter was hot, the paramedic was cute, they *so* should hook up. A slush of hashtags:

#hookthemup, #planebae2 (Mike felt this was actually the worst, but evidently the one that stuck. Twitter was a weird place).

“I just talked to the people in the emergency aisle and they are going to ask to switch seats”

“The flight attendant is in on it”

“The whole plane wants to see this happen”

And then a photo of the two of them, mouths open in surprise (and, Mike noted with both excitement and a sour feeling, delight). Were *his hands* on Hannah? Down below the edge of the photo?

The caption:

“OMG this just happened.”

Tens. Of thousands. Of likes.

It went on from there. RomCom reported that they were talking, laughing, trading elements of their lunch items, getting closer, hands touching? She wasn't sure.

The images swarmed in front of Mike. A photo of them standing by the luggage carousel, phones out, facing each other, smiles on their faces.

Exchanging phone numbers.

RomCom agreed:

“This is the sight of a match being made. Great job Flight 4401. It gives me tingles.”

Mike sank back in his chair.

He scrolled listlessly through the thread, the comments, the photos, each of them like a knife in his heart. The internet was *overjoyed* that hot hero firefighter and hot hero paramedic had been on the same plane (what are the chances?!) and then sat together (the universe works when you make it!) and then hit it off (fate will always win!) and were hopefully exchanging phone numbers because everyone, unanimously, agreed that those two kids were going to have some seriously hot sex.

“I mean, seriously. Hot sex on the horizon.”

On the face of it, Mike reasoned, when he was finally able to do so, there really wasn't much evidence of anything here. Hannah had run into someone she knew. They were both in emergency services. They probably had a lot of shop talk to share. Hell, they had just saved someone's life together and been on the news.

And evidently they were both from somewhere around here, so why *not* exchange numbers? They might even run into each other on the job.

Mike's stomach went cold. He could even be on *their* fire department, for all he knew.

But still, what was that evidence of? Nothing.

He blinked slowly.

There was just one little thing:

Hannah hadn't mentioned this at all.

Time must have passed without him realizing it, because his phone began buzzing, and when he looked at the screen it read 7:00pm.

"Fuck."

He called the nanny, who normally left at 6:30, and promised her three hours of double-time when he got home. Luckily for him, Gosia was an unmarried older woman with nothing to do but feed her cats, and while she claimed to detest tardiness, he believed she secretly loved the overtime for both the money and something to do.

At least he hoped so. She was spic-and-span.

It was raining lightly, which went perfectly with his mood. Nothing like wipers screeching across the windshield in intervals to soothe the troubled mind.

By the time he got home, it was 8:30. The kids barely acknowledged him from their bedrooms, where they were engaging in the final moments of internet accessibility before the whole thing shut down at 9:30.

For them.

Mike still had hours to indulge in his dark fantasies, fueled by the Twitter feed – set on fire by the Twitter feed – before his wife got home and he could confront her.

Or not.

CHAPTER 4

Hannah had a slow shift, which was not what she was looking for under ordinary circumstances, but especially not that night. She wanted action, a lot of it, to keep her mind off the mess with Healy. Maybe a pile-up, or a fire -

Not a fire. Not a big fire all the way in Bowmanville, not a fire requiring all hands on deck, where she could run into Healy again, a smudge of black across his forehead, firm muscles hidden under his bunker gear, sweat pouring down his face and every imaginable inch of his skin -

Stop it.

Fancy meeting you here, she would say.

Stop it.

It was a long night. She had gone onto Twitter, which she barely understood, to look for the “thread” the reporter had been talking about. It took her a long time to find it, but she finally did.

It was the *worst*.

To make matters worse, the bubbly, twenty-year-old Avery Lawrence, who could barely be separated from her phone to go on a call, had found it as well. It figured. She was just the type to follow some obnoxious blogger like “Everyday RomCom.”

“Sooooooo.....” she had said, in that sing-songsy voice that every girl seemed to have these days. Then she had plopped into a chair next to Hannah and grinned wickedly. “Did you hook up with that guy or *what?*”

Hannah had rolled her eyes.

She was married. She was really happily married. Mike was older, but he was attractive as hell, and they had two kids, and she loved him. Just because August Healy, who was undoubtedly attractive, had stirred up a flicker of something she’d long ago stopped feeling with Mike, didn’t mean she was going to run off and fuck him.

“Too young for me, Lawrence,” Hannah quipped. “He’s all yours.” She stood up and headed toward the vending machine.

Avery rolled her eyes and called after her. “Can I have his number? Seriously.”

Her hands were shaking when she put money in the vending machine. What the hell was wrong with her?

Whenever she was asked to participate in some junk team-building exercise, or any other dumb meeting where you had to describe yourself, the first adjective Hannah used for herself was “loyal.” After that, she was honest, assertive, and practical.

Most people would agree with that assessment. Which is why it pained and troubled her that the very idea – more like a feeling – of having an affair was even twisting inside of her. That was disloyal, dishonest... and totally, totally, completely *impractical*.

A bad idea.

No reason to do it.

She was happy with her life, happy with her family, happy with...

“Happy with everything,” she told the vending machine.

She wasn’t tired as she drove home. The reporter’s call had been like a dose of adrenaline, each thought about Gus a dose of epinephrine.

And she was two hours behind.

She pulled into an all-night diner parking lot on the highway and stared into her phone for a long time. The screen stared back blankly at her as she scrolled through her contacts.

She had no friends she could talk to about this.

About what?

She had entered his name into her phone as August Healy when he had given it to her at the airport.

We should have our own dinner sometime, he had said. They weren’t going to get a Lightning Bolt Award for their service, even though it had been the best resuscitation either one of them had ever performed. Two people could barely do the job of CPR just long enough to get a whole team there, but they had done it, and they had brought him back.

He knew a great place for Indian, which she loved. He had a place in the city while he was taking classes at the university.

She was married.

You are married, she had reminded herself.

Hannah stared at the phone.

She had changed his name to “Scott’s Pizza.” As it scrolled past, it made her flicker inside.

All the possibilities were there. They would meet in the city, they would eat... and then what? Drive home?

She could almost feel herself doing it, some balmy evening... lights all around them, the same kind of light rain as tonight still splashed all over the city streets. A blue tint in the sky, the air full of possibilities. Dinner almost uneaten, him smiling over the edge of empty wineglasses, so far away from Redville and yelling children and twelve-hour shifts and the glaze of fluorescent lights in the station... he would look at her, winding up the coil inside her that was getting tighter with every thought of him.

Let's get out of here, he would say.

Hannah closed her eyes. God. He was too young. Affairs were too messy. He was kind of... just too young. She *liked* him, but he was too macho, too naive, too much of a very young, muscled, testosterone-fueled *boy*.

She wound up a little tighter. She was throbbing, even a little bit wet, in the center of her legs.

She spun past Scott's Pizza. What a stupid fake name. She was pretty sure it was from a television show she'd watched about ten years ago. Mike would see through the ruse if he looked into her contact list.

Mike would see through all of this.

And then that reporter. The blog, the Twitter feed.

Why? Why had all of this happened?

She shook her head, put the car in gear. Why did she care?

Loyal, honest, practical Hannah needed to go home. This was a passing frenzy, a carnal desire, and it had the potential to hurt Mike, to ruin their marriage, to throw her life into chaos -

She had a momentary, seductive vision of herself drinking wine in the city, wrapping her legs around Gus in a stairwell because they couldn't make it home, free of everything but the carnal thing she wanted...

She tossed the phone in the passenger seat and drove back onto the highway.

Home.

CHAPTER 5

Mike was up. He was standing in the kitchen, stiff, a confrontational look on his face – and this was not a common expression for Mike, but she recognized it.

Also, it was three in the morning.

She turned to face the door as she closed it. It was a chance to gather her thoughts, make a plan. This was an unfolding emergency.

Assess.

Treat.

Be done with it.

If only it was that easy.

She faced him and shrugged out of her coat. “You’re up late,” she said. “You want to talk.”

Mike nodded. His eyes looked red-rimmed, but it was probably the lack of sleep. Hannah’s eyes took in the wine glass, his stance. Not swaying, a little drunk but not belligerent. Quiet. Thinking.

In the back of her throat, she could feel the words trying to come out: *It’s about the call this morning, the Twitter thing.*

At least, that’s what she needed to say. It was what she wanted to say. It would have been the most honest and loyal thing to say right now.

But something twisted inside of her. Did she *have* to open that box if it wasn’t necessary?

She sat down on one of the tall chairs at the kitchen counter. “What’s up?” she asked. She said it as casually as she could muster.

She could tell by the way that Mike’s eyes flickered, he hadn’t missed a thing.

“What did that journalist want this morning?” he said.

Was it her, or did he sound like he was seething?

Hannah sighed.

“Oh God.”

She looked at her hands.

“I didn’t want to say anything to you, because...” she sighed again. “I just thought, I don’t know. I ran into that firefighter again on the plane, and

it was a pretty cool coincidence, he's a nice guy and everything, but that's it, you know?"

"So why didn't you mention it at all?"

Hannah shrugged.

She inhaled. "I guess... I... look, I didn't know about this Twitter thing. At all. If I had known about that, I would have told you about it right away."

As soon as she said this, she realized that it sounded pretty bad. This was an "I would have said something if I had known I was going to get caught" moment.

She put her hand on her forehead. "I realize that sounds bad," she said. "Ugh. This whole thing is so out of proportion. You know?"

Mike still wasn't saying anything.

Hannah dropped her hand. "I should have said something about running into him on the plane," she said.

There was a long pause. In the stillness in the country, they could hear the buzzing of the single street light on their road. Mike's silence was horrible. He was rarely like this.

Hannah was suddenly grateful that things were coming to a head like this. She felt sufficiently guilty, Mike's silent judgment washing over her, to put all thoughts of Gus out of her head.

This is how it would end, only worse, and she couldn't bear it.

It was a good trial run for the consequences of an affair. All of Hannah's deeply loyal and honest mores were being scalded by the stare of her husband.

And she deserved it, she thought bitterly.

You haven't done anything.

"You still haven't answered my question."

You've thought about it plenty. You almost called him tonight. You told a lie. You put his number in your phone as Scott's Pizza. Come, on Hannah. No one here was born yesterday.

Hannah looked at her hands.

She looked back up at her husband. The conflict inside of her was profound: she really, really wanted to tell the truth. But she also really, really didn't want to hurt Mike's feelings, or give him any reason to believe she would have done the things she had thought about.

But it was her thoughts – thoughts of meeting Gus in the city, thoughts of his skin against her shoulder on the plane, the hard bulge of his muscle against her arm, the way her eyes had strayed to the bulge in his pants... these were all things that she could never, never tell Mike about.

“I didn’t tell you because... I just didn’t want you to feel like, I don’t know, like... anything was going on with that, or, I don’t know...”

She looked at Mike for help, her eyes pleading. *Come on, help me out here.*

“You mean, because he’s good-looking. And a firefighter. And about... what is it? Twenty-five?”

Hannah looked at her hands again.

“Or is it because you are attracted to him, Hannah?”

Hannah’s eyes shot up to look at Mike, and narrowed, just a little, with the slightest bit of intrigue. *That wasn’t like Mike. Saying something like that.*

For some reason, it got her defenses up. “Look,” she said hotly. “He’s an attractive guy, okay? He’s young, he’s a hero firefighter, he’s good-looking... I *knew* you would say something like that. So your question answers your question, okay?”

Mike pulled a bottle of whiskey from out of the suspended cupboards above the counter and uncorked it. Hannah tried to read his expression.

“So you’re not attracted to him?”

Hannah froze. She tried to make her mouth move, but she was torn between lying – something she didn’t like to do – and telling the truth, something, at this moment, she thought would be even worse.

Mike took down another glass. He poured some whiskey into it and nudged it across the table to her.

“I understand if you are,” he said.

Hannah took the glass in her hands, not intending to drink it, and looked at her husband suspiciously.

He said nothing. Just looked back at her.

What the fuck, pardon her French, was this?

She tapped the glass with the pad of her forefinger. Her nails were square and trim, no polish, but pretty.

Nothing from Mike.

“Look,” she said. “He’s a good-looking guy, right?”

She paused for Mike to agree with her, but he just kept staring back at her.

It was weird.

She decided to move on. “He’s a good-looking guy,” she repeated, “It was crazy to see him on the plane home... the flight attendant asked me to move, I did, there he was... it was a big coincidence, we talked, it was nice. That’s it. I just... I felt like if I mentioned it, you’d read more into it than there was. You know?”

Hannah was lying.

The taste of it was sour in her mouth. There was the bile of lying by omission – the flight attendant had asked her to move, but she had already seen Gus by then, already agreed to the move knowing that he was there, walking down the aisle with her heart in her throat, her pulse racing. There was the bitter taste of lying, pure lying, as she spun up this story, which she had only thought of just now. The real reason she hadn’t mentioned the plane was precisely because she *had* wanted to sit by Gus, because her heart had been pounding with excitement through the whole flight, because her eyes *did* stray to the bulge in his pants...

But her lie sounded so *reasonable*.

Mike brought the whiskey to his lips. “So you thought... I’d think, what?”

Hannah shrugged, and found that the lies, like toothpaste from a tube, just kept pouring out. “I thought if I came home and said, ‘hey I saved this guy in Denver and this hot firefighter was there and then we ended up on the plane home together, we sat together and everything, isn’t that cool?’ you’d think, I don’t know... that I was like, interested in him or something.”

Mike raised his eyebrows.

“Which... I, like, he was interesting, and we *did* have an interesting conversation. But not *interesting*-interesting. Not, you know...”

Hannah felt stupid and willed herself to stop talking. She could hear her own voice and cringed inwardly at what she was saying.

“Not... interested-in-you, interesting,” Mike said softly.

The way he looked at her, he seemed to have some secret knowledge of something, and Hannah’s heart plunged. Did he know Gus’s number was in her phone as “Scott’s Pizza?” Did he have some kind of... mind-reading ability? Some secret footage of her?

Doing what? You've talked to a guy on the plane. You thought about his dick. That's all.

Hannah reminded herself that she was a practical person who did not believe in mind-reading.

"Exactly," she managed to say.

There was a long pause.

Mike swirled his wine in his glass. He seemed to be pondering something as he did it, looking into the depths of his wine glass as though there were some kind of answer there.

"So, anyway," Hannah said, suddenly uncomfortable and wanting to get out of this conversation. "There's some crazy human interest story about this, because of, you know, Twitter."

Mike was still looking into his wine. "I saw it," he said coolly.

"What?" Hannah said.

He looked up at her. "I saw it. Missy pointed it out to me."

Hannah's jaw dropped. "What?"

"It's quite the sensation. You have thousands of likes. You're the new 'planebae.'"

"The new what?"

Hannah reached for her phone.

Mike let her swipe at the screen.

"The internet seems to think you'd make a great couple," he said, as her eyes scanned the pages she had found.

Hannah looked at him, the glow of her screen blue on her face. What the hell was he talking about? There was something dark in his voice, which was to be expected... but it was darker than plain jealousy.

It was almost... sexual, or something.

"The internet is full of idiots, like everywhere else," she volleyed back, but the expression on his face made her keep looking at him.

Mike shrugged. "I wouldn't blame you, if you were attracted to him," he said casually.

Hannah's heart stopped for a beat.

Is he kidding? Is he trying to trap me?

"Well," Hannah said, and her voice was very quiet. "He's good-looking. But I'm not attracted to him. So."

"Do you ever think about having an affair?" Mike said abruptly.

She had let her gaze fall to the screen, and the question had raced through her mind, singeing every part of her body, before even a second had passed. *Affair, affair, affair.*

Well, Hannah, do you? Did you spend the whole afternoon thinking about having an affair, or not?

Her pussy throbbed. The ache between her legs, and the quiver of excitement that was wobbling through her body, made her flush with embarrassment. What the hell kind of person was she?

“Of course I don’t think about that seriously,” she said.

She met Mike’s eyes.

She could not believe the heat traveling through her body, the excitement that was poisoning her veins. Her hand was going to start shaking, so she set the phone down. It felt like worms were alive in her chest and stomach, and her pussy was throbbing with a very illicit kind of need, like the time she’d found some dirty magazines at a cousin’s house and masturbated in the bathroom to the images

Why the hell are you turned on by this?

“So you never thought about having an affair with this guy? This, uh... what’s his name? August?”

Hannah had already started to say, “Gus.”

It was too late to take it back.

Mike’s mouth turned up in a wry kind of smile.

“Right,” he said.

They looked at each other for a tense, boiling moment.

“So it was all just a coincidence that you were so turned on the other night,” Mike said.

Hannah’s heart raced.

“You know something,” she said icily, “I don’t appreciate what you’re insinuating.”

But for some reason, this only made her arousal more intense. Her cheeks flushed again with a red-hot... something. Something like shame and excitement and real anger.

Mike sighed. And then, shockingly, he said: “You know, some women have affairs with younger men, and their husbands are okay with it.”

Hannah stared at him. Her heart was bouncing against her ribcage with a gale force, she felt sure she was going to have a cardiac event if she didn’t watch it. Her ears were ringing.

She tried to keep calm.

She tried to laugh. It sounded odd in her throat, more of a warble. She had to bring a hand to her neck and shrug. “Well,” she said primly. “We aren’t those people, are we?”

She swallowed her wine and started talking before she looked at Mike again, because he had such a strange expression on his face and she didn’t know what to make of any of this. Was he being serious? Testing the waters? Testing *her*, trying to get her to admit to being attracted to Gus?

No. What kind of a guy would say something like that and be *serious* about it?

“Anyway,” she said, trying to wrap things up. “I’m sorry about the whole... Twitter thing. I didn’t know about it, I swear. So... anyway, I told the reporter no, the whole thing will die down any minute, and... that will be that.” She made a loud sound and stretched her arms in front of her. “I have to take a bath,” she said. “I lifted like three huge patients today.”

She walked around the counter.

They kissed sort of awkwardly. “Sort of,” because there was a lot of heat within Hannah: she was turned on, though she wasn’t sure what it was that had her so wound up. She was sure that Mike was, too. Sure that she felt his hard cock brush against her thigh.

But the kiss was one of those marital sideswipes, almost perfunctory, brief and unwanting.

Their eyes met.

Hannah’s voice was shaking, and her insides were quivering, as she turned and walked toward the master bedroom. “Night. Don’t stay up too late.”

CHAPTER 6

He wasn't sure why he did it.

He had felt so close, there in the dark kitchen in the middle of the night, to telling her his secret. He thought he could feel her own secrets pulsing beneath her skin, and the two of them had been orbiting inward toward each other, toward saying the unspeakable: he, that he really wanted her to have an affair, and she, that she also wanted to.

But this was the kind of thing that had to be mutual, and if it wasn't, it had the powerful potential to ruin things between them.

So he had chickened out at the very last minute, there with her lips brushing over his for a goodnight kiss.

She left, he heard the water running. With a chance to be out of the heat she had been radiating, he cooled down, tried to be rational.

Hannah was not going to have an affair. And Hannah definitely wasn't going to have an affair because he *asked* her to have one with a twenty-five year old guy she met on a plane. Hannah was definitely not going to look him in the eye while she got on her knees and swallowed that guy's cock.

He was reading into Hannah's body language, into the heat on Hannah's skin, what he wanted to be there. He wanted her to be turned on by another man, and so he was imagining that sexual energy was pulsing beneath her skin, imagining that he could smell her excitement when she stood close to him.

He had finished the wine, set the glass down, and walked through the house toward the bedroom. A dull roar filled his ears, making it hard to hear. The water was still running, though, and he could hear that over his own blood pulsing.

He pushed the door open slowly, registered sound of the water in the bathtub, saw motion between the cracks of the Chinese panel Hannah had placed between the en-suite tub and the part of the room that was a bedroom (she'd hated the open-concept floor plan, especially the bedroom running into the bathroom).

He padded toward the screen, softly, knowing, somehow, what he would see. He hated what he was going to see, and yet he wanted to look at

it, to feel the satisfying rush of being right, the tingle of seeing for himself that his wife's mind was filled with betrayal.

Or did he? The image of the bathroom grew larger and more complete with every step. As he moved from side to side and closer, he caught a different slice of what was in there. Before long he was next to the space between the panels, looking in at his wife, at her leg draped over one side of the tub. At the movement of her shoulder, a strange and fluttering movement. At her closed eyes, her half-open mouth, her shaking limbs.

He stared as the water filled the tub, unchecked, and Hannah's hand moved faster beneath the surface. His cock pulsed as her lower lip fell down, and her eyes opened, and she stared at the wall in front of her, her shoulders shaking slightly.

And what was she thinking about, there in the bathtub?

Or better stated, *who* was she thinking about?

He could have done a lot of things at that moment. Maybe that had been the right moment to confront Hannah, to tell her his own deeply-buried secret, when she still had her fingers in the folds of her own pussy and her cheeks were red with the excitement of masturbating, thinking about Gus. It was an easy bet, almost a guarantee.

But he stepped back, and went out to the kitchen, and waited for her to go to bed. Then he indulged in his own fantasies.

It was for the best, he decided, sweating in the basement, stuffing a used hand towel into the washer with some other laundry, running the load late at night and hoping Hannah wouldn't notice and ask him about it. It was for the best to leave all of this as it was. He knew it, and Hannah knew it, and if all that came of this was fantasy – she having hers in the bathtub, and he indulging his in the guest bathroom – it was for the best.

Because real affairs ran real risks. Real consequences. They had a good marriage, and this would all die down, just like Hannah had said it would. They would go on with their life just like before, with nothing more than a sweet, strange interlude of fantasy.

All for the best.

But...

Despite Hannah's conviction that the story would just run out of steam, it did not. Once the internet found out that Gus and Hannah were both from the same area, that they might cross paths again in the future at

an emergency scene, that Hannah was married, that he was so young, that Hannah wouldn't do the interview, that he did, that he was as charming as he was good-looking, that he had rescued a child from a deadly fire three years ago just one month after completing his firefighter training... the story just found more steam from that bottomless well of energy that swirled in the vast expanses of the internet.

And the internet *loved* his wife. Loved the idea of her and Gus together. Loved to speculate that Hannah was a good person for not doing the interview, but probably was secretly hooking up with Gus. *I'd do him in a minute*, claimed Twitter handle after Twitter handle.

And so, after-hours at the clinic, Mike mired in the Twitter soup that was #planebae2, in the stories about the story, in the speculative stories about the story about the story, in the opinion columns that went as far as the Washington Post (*#PlaneBae2, and Other Things The Internet Broke*). A journalist contacted him *at work* hoping to get his side of the story.

At work.

Him.

All the while, he waited for it to go away.

And it really *had* gone away. It wasn't as if any of this was happening on the front pages of the internet. It wasn't the sort of thing that every single friend or neighbor saw, it wasn't like the press was camped out on his lawn.

He had to look for it. And if you have to look for something on the internet, is it even really there?

But he *imagined* plenty. He imagined that every client who looked at him strangely had seen Channel 2's interview, and was feeling sorry for the plain, middle-aged man whose harlot of a wife was having a torrid affair with a hot firefighter she'd met on a plane.

He imagined that Hannah was doing all the things the internet was speculating, encouraging, hoping she had done. He sat in the glow of the slowly dying Twitter thread and pictured her sneaking off with him, sending him text messages, calling him late at night in the parking lot from her base station. Thinking of him while she took a bath, her fingers on her clit, relieving the ache she felt between her legs to have August Healy's cock inside of her.

It was wild, perverse fantasy. But he couldn't stop himself.

*

It would be a lie to tell anyone, especially Mike, that she never thought about August Healy. Or that she never swiped through the slowly-dying Internet memes about them, which spiked from day to day, but mostly ebbed away, like everything on the internet does.

It was easy enough to pretend it had never happened.

But when she thought about it, a curious kind of chill overtook her. She couldn't figure out what it was: it felt like the same adrenaline from back when she'd been a rookie. It felt a little like the stomach-twisting sensation of falling in love.

And it felt far more raw, more sexual, more *dirty* than she was used to feeling.

The guy was so young.

She was married.

She tried to push it out of her mind.

She didn't call him, because she didn't want to make waves. She watched him on Channel Two. He was smart, sweet, photogenic, and polite. The piece was short, he laughed off most of the questions, and he never called her about it, or whatever had happened between them.

She had paused in her car many times, her fingers hovering over his "name" in her phone, alternating between thoughts of deleting him and thoughts of calling him.

In the end, she did neither, and that was going to be the end of it... a slow, decision-less death to what was, in the end, just a fanciful moment that gave her a cheap thrill, and was now over.

Until...

CHAPTER 7

The call had come just as she had been heading into work. Operating guidelines were that personal phones were a no-no, even between calls, but that was a rule everyone explicitly broke. People texted all the time, only half-bothering to cover up what they were doing, and everyone else knew the texts were personal.

You just didn't answer the phone. But who *called* anymore?

So when her phone buzzed away in her pants as she was making herself a coffee on a slow night, she almost hadn't reached for it. Only scammers and solicitors, and sometimes Verizon, *called* her phone.

Something made her fish it out to look at it. She was alone, leaning against the counter, waiting for the drip coffee to fill the filthy pot, staring into space. It was almost two months since the fated meeting with Gus, two months since her husband had said all of that weird shit. The fantasy was fading, the idea of having an affair becoming less and less of a go-to daydream, the distance and time between them dulling her heated reaction to August Healy.

She glanced down at the phone, expecting to see an 800-number and tuck it away. One hand was on her coffee mug, she would need the phone hand to pour, she was thinking about sugar -

Scott's Pizza.

A cold, electrifying feeling shuddered through her. It was like the feeling of being caught doing something very bad. The feeling of seeing a boy you had a crush on walking down the hallway in high school. An adolescent, overly-passionate, jolt. It was chilling and scorching at the same time.

She froze, the coffee finishing up, her left hand on the mug, the phone buzzing in her palm of her right hand, the screen telling her the impossible, the worst, the best thing she could imagine:

Gus was calling her.

And then, just like that, a call came in, and the phone was dropped into her pants. The coffee abandoned, her compartmentalized mind quickly changed to call-mode.

But the rapid heartbeat did not so easily fade.

Hannah had been a paramedic for a long time, so she easily turned the personal part of her brain off for calls. This call was a VSA – vital signs absent – for an older gentleman who had been found by a cleaning lady.

There were two more calls in succession after that, keeping her mind focused – but just barely – on the task at hand.

It wasn't until her shift was over and the truck restocked, as she was climbing into her car to go home, that Gus's call sent the same, electrifying excitement and shame through her. She shivered and set her purse down in the passenger seat, determined to ignore the call, and the tantalizing possibility of a message, until she could calm down.

She was so *stupid*, she was acting like a child.

She made it as far as the turn for the highway that took her on a pretty, meandering path home, before she pulled over to a wide shoulder and took the phone out of her purse.

Her heart fluttered when she saw that he had left a message, though it was hard to say what emotion stimulated the flutter.

She chewed on her lip.

The *right* thing to do would be to never listen to it.

Well, the right thing to do would have been to never take his number, never give him hers, to not have entered his number in her phone as “Scott's Pizza.”

God, that was a like a bad plot device from a B-grade movie.

She stared at the screen.

It *could* be important.

And while she knew that wasn't likely to be possible, it was the lie she told herself as she pressed her thumb against the icon for her voicemail, and brought the phone to her ear.

Her body was vibrating with a feeling she hadn't felt for a long time as she waited through the voicemail's anodyne message.

And then there was his voice, conjuring his hard muscle beneath his gray shirt, the tightness of his jeans against his fit thighs, the day's worth of stubble along his firm jawline, the fullness of his mouth and how it looked like he'd be very good at -

Stop it.

“Hey. Hannah. This is August Healy. I was calling, uh... I thought maybe you'd want to get together for a drink, talk about old times. You said you sometimes head into the city, so... I've been waiting for you to call.

But you didn't. So I figure you must have lost my number." He laughed lightly. "I think this 'planebae two' thing has blown over, so we can avoid the paparazzi. So... yeah, call me back, if you'll be heading this way any time."

So fucking confident. So goddamn sure of himself. Like he doesn't know I'm married, like me not doing that interview wasn't clue enough that I wasn't going to call him back, ever.

Hannah sighed and hung up the phone. Her veins were filled with adrenaline, or something. She was as jittery as though she'd downed sixteen cups of coffee.

And a bottle of wine.

She stared into the dull, late summer sunlight and squinted, which she was hoping would give her some more perspective on life.

I mean, this guy, really, she thought. So much swagger. Just calling her up, asking her out, just like that. No pretense, no fumbling around, no excuse. Just, let's meet for a drink, Hannah, even though you're married.

To be fair, she argued with herself, she hadn't exactly been forthcoming about being married on the plane.

In fact, she hadn't talked about that at all.

Deliberately.

What kind of message had that sent to him?

She looked at the phone in her hand.

Undoubtedly, the wrong message. The very most-wrong message she could have sent. The thought of having omitted that crucial piece of information from their plane conversation was a ball of guilt, heavy in her chest.

She would *not*, definitely *not*, call him back.

She turned on her car again, to punctuate the point for herself.

She imagined him leaving that message, his sandy hair unkempt, the sort of shit-eating, overconfident grin on his face that great-looking, confident, hot young guys have when they know they can get whatever they want.

Asshole.

So why was her abdomen stirring with cool, delicious rivulets of desire? Why was her pussy starting to ache? Why was her mind flashing image after image of this guy behind her eyes?

She stared at the dashboard, her hand on the shifter, willing herself to move it into drive, take her foot off the brake, ease onto the highway... This was like the long first shifts, back when she first came on as a paramedic: just make it through the next five minutes, now the next. Just *move forward*, don't think about how hard the entire day is. Just move.

Instead, she found herself picking the phone up again, listening to his voice again, muttering that he was a real asshole again, thinking about how she was lying to her husband again...

And all the while, her mind went ahead, through her schedule, through Mike's, through all the possibilities, through her possible excuses for going into the city... she settled on one, she concocted the plan, she could already see herself there.

She put the car in drive. She was doing well, she wasn't calling him back.

But in the back of her mind, of course, she knew it was a lie.

She wasn't calling him back because she wanted to think about what she would say.

By the time she got home, she had managed to convince herself that calling him back was not such a terrible thing to do. She had a doctor's appointment in the city in a week and a half. There was no reason why she couldn't meet him for a neutral, non-sexual drink – she would order a non-alcoholic beverage – and just... clear everything up. Set her boundaries. Tell him what was what, and get him off her mind.

She would tell Mike about it, as a fail-safe.

That's what she would do.

She called him two days later, on the side of the road, after leaving early enough for her shift that she could make the call.

"Hannah Moore," he said, answering the phone. His voice was sexy, almost as though the stubble on his jaw had been turned into a sound. She pictured his lips moving as he said her name, lost her composure, fumbled for a moment.

"Hey, uh... Gus. August. Healy," she said stupidly. Then she started blathering. "Hey so, I got your message, sorry I didn't call earlier, I just, really busy, two shifts, you know... everything else..."

Why couldn't she bring herself to say: husband, kids?

“...and uh... well, it just so happens, I’ll be in the city in.. next week, on Friday, I have an appointment, so... yeah, you know, if you’re around, let’s meet up for a drink or something.”

There was a pause, and to her it seemed to last forever. What was she, thirteen years old? Her stomach was in knots, her pussy was aching, her chest felt like someone was standing on it.

“What time is your appointment, Hannah?”

Gus’s voice was as smooth as silk. *Calm. Hot.*

Fuck, I cannot believe I am falling for this shit, Hannah thought.

“It’s at one, I’ll be done... I don’t know, maybe two or so.”

There was another long pause.

“What time do you have to be home, Hannah?”

Her chest grew tighter.

There was no other way to interpret that, was there? Other than what it was: a scarcely hidden invitation to... what?

Hannah’s lips moved, but she wasn’t able to formulate a coherent thought.

“I mean, I don’t have to be back right away,” she said, trying desperately to sound as suave as Gus.

“I have class until four, is why,” he continued smoothly. “Is that too late for you?”

It was. It was definitely too late. Everything, it seemed, was getting a little too late.

“Oh, yeah, that’s fine,” she said. “I have some shopping I could do.”
So lame.

“Great,” he said. “So next Friday. I know a really good spot close to my place, in Cabbagetown. I’ll send you the address.”

“Okay. Great.”

“I’m looking forward to seeing you, Hannah.”

Hannah’s heart plunged. “Yeah,” she said. “Me...uh, me too.”

“Bye.”

“Bye. See you then.”

You sound. Like a fucking idiot.

She slipped the phone into her purse. Her chest was light now, her blood racing, the same queer tingle in her ears, like Brownian ringing.

Man, that guy was a piece of work. So sure she’d say yes, so smooth on the phone.

He was twenty-five years old, for God's sake.

Talking to her like that.

Okay, she thought, pulling back onto the highway. You just go to this one thing. You're just playing around, just having a *taste* of excitement. You're not going to actually do anything.

"Oh, Hannah," she said quietly to herself. "This is all such a bad idea."

*

He didn't want to be suspicious of his wife.

But he was.

The first few weeks after her return, he tried looking into her phone.

She didn't start walking around with it more than usual, or taking it to bed with her when she had to go to sleep earlier for an odd shift. When he did dig into her phone, he didn't find anything particularly incriminating, either.

No strange numbers.

No text conversations.

But there was a stubborn persistence to his suspicions and fantasies. Rather than finding a lack of evidence that his wife was having an affair to be exculpatory, he decided it was proof that she *was* having an affair, and that it was even more deliciously horrible because she was covering it up so well. He decided that she must have deleted messages, and if she had done that, they must be salacious and damning

And so he went a little crazy, getting online and poring over a detailed text and voice usage list.

There wasn't much there. Most calls and texts were to him, or the nanny, or the kids. The other numbers checked out as numbers to her friends, her supervisor.

Nothing unusual.

No calls to August Healy.

He wasn't sure what it was he wanted to find. Did he really want his wife to have an affair? Or did he not? Was he digging to find something he delighted in, or something he hated?

Even *he* didn't know. He felt a mixture of disappointment and relief when his searches turned up nothing.

The weeks went by, and he began to think that this had all been a glancing brush with possibilities, an exciting little pulse in their marriage, and nothing more. If anything, it had given him some hope, a chance to feel out the waters and get an idea if he could ever come clean to Hannah about his fantasies.

It sort of seemed like that was a “no.”

But it had been fun.

And then, she reawakened his suspicions, about three weeks after her trip.

What was it that tipped him off? Hannah had a doctor in the city she didn't want to give up. There was nothing new under the sun about her having an appointment there. It had probably been scheduled for six months.

Was it the *way* she mentioned it?

She was leaning against the counter, her eyes on a magazine, her foot resting on top of her other foot, her elbow against the counter-top. What was it about the way she was standing? It looked sort of posed.

Her breasts were tight against a thin white sweater, which caught the light when she faced the window, and allowed just a hint of her areola to be seen. Her hair was loosely gathered at her neck, curly strands falling about her cheeks.

She kept her eyes on the magazine, but she seemed to be watching him peripherally.

Didn't she?

“Oh,” she said out of nowhere. Her eyes were still on the magazine. “I just remembered. I have an appointment with Dr. Andrews on Friday.”

Was it because she didn't look up when she said this?

Mike's spine tingled. His skin pimples on his forearms. “Oh, yeah?” he said casually, watching her with interest.

She didn't look up. “It's later,” she said. “I might not be home until later.”

The back of Mike's neck was alive, as though covered in worms.

Why?

Was it because Hannah, Hannah who always committed to times in precise increments and using military time, had not committed to anything in this statement except: “later?”

“How late?” he said.

Hannah didn't look up. Her eyes were rigidly, unwaveringly fixated on her magazine. Which was, Mike noted with even more suspicion, the AAA quarterly magazine.

Not exactly scintillating.

"Uh... three, I think. It's just, like a longer appointment, and then there's traffic and stuff."

"Three." Not fifteen-hundred hours. Around three, and then a longer appointment. "And stuff."

Mike's stomach started to churn again.

He desperately, desperately wanted to ask her if she was planning to see August Healy. He *knew* she was, he knew there was something up with her.

But he also really wanted her to be telling the truth, for himself to be fantasizing, reading more into a truthful conversation than was there.

And he also really wanted her to be lying... and for her to go through with it.

If he said something about it, would she still do it?

"Why a long appointment?" he asked, casually.

Hannah looked over at him. "What?" she said.

He felt a thrilling stab through the heart. He'd caught her off-guard. She *was* lying, and there was something deliciously fun in this dance with her.

It was perverse. But it was true.

"Why the long appointment? With Doctor Andrews?"

"Oh," she said, and pushed her hair back. The "oh" was a stall for time, she didn't have an answer. "Just.. he has some tests he wants to do. It's... so yeah, the appointment isn't at three, the tests are." She held up her magazine, and gave him a smile.

Now he was doubting himself.

"I must have been really caught up in this, huh?" She was smiling now, looking him in the eye. "Anyway, yeah, sorry. I'll be late getting home on Friday."

"I was hoping for a romantic date," he said, fishing.

And there it was. A flicker across her face. A flush - light pink and almost invisible - along her jawline, where her teeth gritted and her jaw pulsed as she remained calm.

But something had stirred inside of her.

“Next week?” she said meekly. “Sorry.”

CHAPTER 8

She didn't know why she did it.

Why was she lying to Mike about meeting August, especially when all of their conversations had indicated that he *wanted* her to stray, wanted her to try something out?

Deep down inside, she was starting to believe he was serious.

But what she wasn't convinced of was that it would be a good thing for their marriage, especially if he was serious. What did that say about them? What did it say about what he thought of her?

She couldn't even begin to get to the bottom of that.

But the next logical step was decidedly *not* to go ahead with seeing August anyway. It didn't even make any sense. But the way she was rationalizing it was that she intended to see August for drinks and drinks only, and so it wasn't even worth mentioning to her husband. Whether he was serious about what he had said or not. If he *had* been serious, he would be disappointed, because she had no intention of sleeping with August. And if he hadn't been serious, then he didn't need to know about something he'd just worry about.

She knew, though, that all of that rationalization was just that: rationalization.

The heavy rock of guilt in her chest did not stop her from thinking far more than was appropriate about what she would wear into the city, or what she would say when she saw him.

She abandoned telling herself that there was *nothing* going on: she was meeting August Healy for a drink. She was *flirting* with disaster, standing close to it, letting it breathe on her, but in the end, that was all she was going to do. She wasn't going to have an affair with a twenty-five year old guy.

Especially not some cock-sure, cocky, *cock* like Gus, who had coolly texted her the directions to the "cool spot" he knew. Nothing more. Like, he was just *so sure* she'd show up and fall all over herself for him.

She had half a mind to stand him up, send him a text, tell him something had come up, serve him up a dish of his own nonchalant attitude.

Half a mind.

The other half of her mind was doing wild and crazy things. Like getting her hair dyed in a rush appointment after work. Not that her hair needed much dying; she had no grays, and she was a natural blonde. But it didn't hurt to brighten up her highlights.

Mike hadn't even noticed. That's how subtle they were.

Then there was the matter of shaving her legs. It wasn't as if she *never* did that. She was lax about it, sure; it helped that she was blonde, and she had to wear long pants as part of her uniform, and she lived in the country so when she did wear shorts no one saw her, and she and Mike had sex so infrequently that he probably wouldn't even notice anything like that.

He certainly wouldn't turn her down over it.

But it wasn't as if it *never* happened, she thought, as she shaved them completely smooth that Thursday night.

Again, it went unnoticed by Mike, in all likelihood.

There was the outfit-thing. But who didn't want to look good for a trip into the city? There had been a time when she had dressed nicely every day. Sexily. Prettily. A time when she had worn her hair down, straightened it for certain occasions, put on lip gloss and cleaned up blemishes on her face with the tiniest bit of foundation. A time when she had worn mascara every day to darken her ultra-light eyelashes.

For the longest time now, she'd been a sweats, maybe jeans, and hair-in-a-bun kind of gal around the house. Work was a uniform, and she didn't do much else besides work and sports. Even on her trip to Denver, she'd felt a little odd wearing a pair of slacks she'd bought ages ago for a job interview she hadn't even taken in the end.

She had a few cute things: a nice black dress, a suit for special functions like funerals.

She pushed through hanger after hanger of rarely worn clothing in her closet.

She didn't want to look like she was trying, but she didn't want to look like a slob.

Why did all of her clothes have North Face symbol on them?

She tried on a skirt, a really cute one she'd bought on a trip. It was casual, for someone who worked in an office. Paired with a nice tight black blouse, it looked really good on her. Sexy.

But it looked like she was trying.

And she wasn't *trying*, she reminded herself. She was having a little bit of fun, she was maybe flirting a little, maybe enjoying herself and the fantasy that a man as young and hot as August Healy could *want* to get in her pants, but she wasn't *actually* trying to do any of that.

She tossed the skirt into a steadily-growing heap in the corner of the closet.

What was she even doing? she wondered, as she slid through her clothes. It was a bad sign that she was even thinking about this.

Mike would notice if she wore a skirt. He would be suspicious – she was certain he already was, a little bit.

And *Gus* would notice. He would know that she had dressed up to see him. And he was a cock-sure little shit who could *not* be allowed to know that kind of thing.

Hannah put her hands on her hips and sighed at her reflection.

What would you wear if this was really just an appointment with Dr. Andrews, you hussy?

She grimaced, leaning over to pick up a shirt that had slipped off a hanger, and said quietly, aloud: “You can’t do *that*, ” with a laugh, thinking about how she’d show up in running tights and a sweaty long-sleeved wicking shirt.

She jumped through her skin when a voice from behind her, asked out of nowhere: “Can’t do what?”

She clutched her heart, and her whole back came alive with goosebumps. “Jesus!” she exclaimed, even though by then she was over the shock. She knew it was Mike, and her mind was looking for a reason for having said something to her shirt.

A reason that did not involve telling the truth: she was telling herself she couldn’t go to the city in running gear because she wanted to look good – not too good, not *not-too-good* – for August Healy.

“You scared the shit out of me,” she whispered, folding the shirt into very small squares, to hide her shakiness.

“What is it you can’t do?” Mike said, sitting down on the bed.

Hannah set the shirt on a shelf and brushed a lock of hair from her face, her mind reeling wildly for an answer, any answer. “Oh,” she said. “You scared me so much I completely forget what I was thinking about.”

Her voice sounded guilty, she noted. God, she was so full of shit. She tapped on the shelf. “What are... what are you doing home, anyway?”

Mike's eyes were traveling up and down her body. She was glad that she was still in the underwear she was deliberating about; a grayish cotton pair, a little stretched, perfectly awful.

She figured if she wore those, then she would be too mortified to take her clothes off. This was a deep-down buried thought that she didn't think about *too* much.

Because she wouldn't be doing *anything like that*.

Did he see that she had also taken special care to trim her bush? It wasn't as though she never did that, it wasn't like she was *only* doing it for August Healy.

It just looked suspicious.

Why did you do it? Her conscience jeered.

Her chest fluttered with quick breaths. "God, you really scared me," she said, to provide herself some cover.

She turned around, and started pushing through her closet.

"Getting all dressed up to go to Dr. Andrews?" Mike said.

Hannah's spine tingled. She had known he would notice. Now what?

He totally suspects something. Why don't you just come clean? her conscience insisted.

There's nothing to come clean about, piped up the devil on her shoulder. *You haven't actually done anything yet, and you won't. You wouldn't tell him about every single friend you meet for lunch. Why is this any different?*

"I just had a wild hair," she found herself saying. "I kind of want to look, you know, sophisticated while I go into town." She looked over her shoulder, annoyed suddenly that he was home. "What are you doing here, anyway? Don't you have a vet to run?"

Mike didn't answer. She could imagine him rolling his eyes. It didn't sound anything like her, having a wild hair to wear nice clothes and look – she almost laughed at herself – *sophisticated*.

Her annoyance that he was there suddenly dispersed.

Who cared why he had come home? It was kind of a sign, wasn't it? A sign that she should leave on her terrible underwear, that she should just wear a regular outfit, that she should take every precaution to keep from doing anything *real* with Gus Healy.

It's probably a sign, you nitwit, that you shouldn't even meet Gus Healy... her conscience began.

She pulled down a black cowl-neck sweater from the top shelf of the closet. It was trendy, tight-fitting sweater made of thin cashmere that looked sophisticated and not overtly sexy. A good choice, she commended herself. She chose her best pair of jeans to go under it, a pair that fit her snugly and highlighted her firm physique. They would look nice with a pair of high-heeled black boots she had in mind.

“What do you think?” she asked Mike, turning around and showing him the outfit.

Mike was leaning on his knees, looking at her with a really unusual stare.

“That’s not very sophisticated,” he said. “If that’s what you’re going for.”

The statement was charged. He was looking right into her, and she could tell that he knew more than he was letting on – more about her feelings, more about her choice of outfit. Her chest felt constricted again. Her breath was caught in her throat.

“It’s not bad,” she said quietly.

“Do you have a skirt or something?”

What the hell was going on? Hannah wondered.

“Why are you here?” she said, deflecting.

Mike put his fingers to each other in a pointed shape, and then to his lips. “I had to come back for some supplies I left in the shed.”

Hannah ruffled her hair. “Well.”

She walked over to him, leaned in, and gave him a kiss. “Well,” she said. “It’s nice to see you.”

He slipped his hand behind her knee. There was something a little menacing about it, something “off” in the way he was looking at her.

Or was it just her guilty conscience?

“Have time for a quickie?” he asked, his fingers playing with the back of her knee.

Hannah looked quickly at the clock, trying to hide that she was looking in that direction. “It’s almost eleven,” she said reluctantly. She actually didn’t have much time for a quickie... not if she was actually going to make it to her appointment at one.

And look good doing it.

But Mike’s hand was climbing up her leg, and the heavy feeling of guilt pressed on her chest, and something, *something*, about everything she

was doing, made her hungry to have sex.

Thoughts of her shaved legs and her trimmed bush fluttered through her head.

But Mike never notices those things, her devil whispered. And even if he did, wouldn't that be kind of fun?

There was an idea that had never really occurred to her before, not as plainly as all that.

It surged through her, made her pussy ache, and so when Mike grasped her hips and twisted her onto the bed, pulling at her jeans, she didn't resist, and she didn't tell him that she really, really, didn't have enough time.

*

Competing evidence.

Mike gripped the wheel of his car.

He was driving the wrong way. Missy was calling and calling, and he could not imagine the edge to her voice when he finally – for he would finally have to answer – picked up the phone. She couldn't cover for him all day, he had appointments to keep, he had the supplies she needed, he had no time. to be lurking around the road south of theirs, his car pointed at the highway about a quarter of a mile down the road, ready to follow his wife all the way to the city.

No time.

He rolled toward the highway.

There were the shaved legs.

Perfectly smooth, totally silky, something Hannah rarely did. Had she shaved her legs because she was going to the city to have an affair with the fireman? Was she even going to the city? How long had her legs been shaved?

There were the highlights in her hair.

And then – and he found this the most damning of all – there was her very well-trimmed bush, which Hannah was less lazy about than her legs, for some reason. But still. As he had pulled her jeans away and then her underwear -

The underwear. Don't forget about that, he thought. There was no way in hell a woman was going to wear underwear like that to see a man

she wanted to fuck.

- and then brushed his lips along her smooth, freshly shaved inner thigh, all the way to the feathery down of her bush, it had been impossible not to notice that her skin was baby-smooth all around, her hair neatly shaved into a white-blond landing strip, her candy-red pussy glistening in the white of her skin, like a delicious sweet.

And she had been so excited. So wet in his mouth, her flesh bursting like an overripe fruit. Sweet, a little tangy. Had she given herself to another man already? Had someone else been lapping at her clit, making her mewl, making her thighs quiver next to his ears?

It could all just be a coincidence.

His stomach was in knots. What did he want it to be?

CHAPTER 9

It was 1:30 by the time she could see the skyline of the city. She wasn't going to make it to her doctor's appointment, which was a snag that could come back to haunt her with Mike.

Her insides twisted and something plunged inside of her, a heavy weight of guilt, a thrilling little spin on it that ricocheted inside of her.

Mike. The husband she loved, she *loved*, the man she didn't want to hurt: she was doing something very, very wicked with him.

And it felt *good*.

Sex with Mike had been pretty good when they had first started dating. In retrospect Hannah imagined that everyone had good sex before they had children, and that after that it all pretty much went to shit.

But since August Healy – who she had to remind herself constantly she had never actually done anything *with* – had come into her life, sex with *Mike* had come a long way.

It made her abdomen quiver with a cool, delicious, terrible feeling when she thought about why that might be. It wasn't that she was thinking entirely about Gus while she fucked her husband... though to be fair, she let a few thoughts into her head about it. But she thought more about how illicit it was, how it was on the wrong side of things, how Mike's suspicion seemed to make him more possessive, a better lover, more *into* her.

There was something about it being forbidden that was almost more fun than it being real.

But Mike doesn't know that, her conscience told her primly.

Hannah swatted her conscience away.

At first, she had put on the same underwear, and the jeans and cashmere sweater, and kissed Mike goodbye in her clothes. She was planning to wear them -

You were never really planning that. You hussy. You just wanted him to think that's what you were doing, while you were planning all along, even while you kissed him and ran your fingers down his chest, to go take a shower, to put on your black lingerie.

Her chest grew tight. She *had* done all that. But had she planned it that way all along?

She had taken a shower, but that was just because Mike's cum was running down her legs.

She had changed her underwear, but that was just because her other underwear were soaked with Mike's cum.

She had put on the same outfit.

Which grew considerably sexier with the addition of the open-toed, black boots with four-inch heels.

She *had* spent extra time on her hair, smoothing it with a straightener. And she had put on red lipstick.

Then wiped it off, and replaced it with a pale pink.

And that was why she was missing her appointment.

But some of those things, she reasoned with herself, had just been practical. She couldn't go to the doctor smelling like cum.

You're not making it to the doctor, though, are you Hannah?

Her conscience was relentless.

But not, it would seem, relentless enough.

It was two o'clock when she reached the downtown core. Two hours to change her mind.

But the two hours passed quickly, and she was still there, staring out the window of a Starbuck's, when her vibrating phone sent her stomach into cartwheels.

[Scott's Pizza]: *You around? I'm done early*

Hannah stared at the phone.

To be honest, it didn't especially seem like him. At least, not the cocky-bastard image of him she was building up in her mind. She could feel the shapes and contours of her heart as she looked at the screen.

Was she really doing this?

What was she even doing?

She typed back:

[Me]: *I can be there in fifteen minutes*

She fled to a public restroom, her heart pounding, and locked herself into a stall, leaning against the back of it, willing herself to calm down.

She could be there in two minutes, if he wanted to know. She could be there in two minutes, and she could feel in her thighs that she could come in ten if they got right to it.

Jesus, you slut. What are you even talking about?

Okay. She took a deep breath.

She was going to have a nice dinner-y thing, with not too much alcohol, and then she was going to drive home, and this – whatever it was – was going to be over.

*

His eyes moved up and down her body as she walked toward him.

It wasn't in a creepy way, it was a sensual way, a way that made her feel every inch of his gaze, as though he were actually touching her.

It definitely was *not* in a non-obvious way. Or in a non-sexual way.

She met his eyes, wanting to scold him a little with her expression. It failed miserably, even if he was full of himself. He looked *good*.

He was in jeans again, and a black, slightly dressier t-shirt, but still a t-shirt, clinging to his muscles, showing tantalizing glimpses of the muscles of his abdomen, the contour of his pecs, the raw, masculine shape of him that certainly didn't end at the waist just because he was under a table –

Oh God, he was standing up. She had to force her eyes to look at his hairline so that they wouldn't drift down.

Even in her heels, August was taller than her by a good five inches. His brown hair was mussed; he had the kind of haircut that made his hair look model-styled with no effort. A faint shadow of stubble was appearing on his jaw again, and Hannah thought about how it would feel on the inside of her thigh just as she, very awkwardly, extended her hand toward him.

He cocked his head, took her hand in his, and brought it to his lips. They were warm and dry, and another disturbing set of thoughts about her inner thighs raced through her head about as fast as the sensation of his lips on her hand traveled straight to her pussy and made her wet.

Hannah smiled, tried to pull herself together, and then said something really stupid, like, "Of course."

He pulled her very gently toward him by the hand, which he still held in his very firm, lightly calloused grip, and then he gave her a hug. Hannah closed her eyes, the heat of his body against hers. He was solid, everywhere

she touched him, and every inch of his skin was traveling straight through her to the lowest parts of her abdomen, coiling up, making her hot.

And wet.

He smelled like cedar, musk, and manliness. Clean, a little dirty, somewhere in there a hint of oil.

Get a fucking grip on yourself.

“It’s good to see you,” he said, before he let her go. His breath traveled through her hair, to the back of her neck, and her entire back lit up in gooseflesh.

Hannah felt like she should say something, but she didn’t dare. If her mouth was as untrustworthy as every other part of her body was, she needed to keep it shut.

Just like your knees, her conscience added. Keep those shut, too.

Don’t, purred her devilish side. Open them up and get some of that between -

“So,” Hannah said, to cut off her own thoughts. She cleared her throat. “What’s, uh... good here?”

Gus smiled, and Hannah made a note that it was a cocky smile, but for some reason it didn’t vex her as much as she wanted it to. He looked around, then looked back at her amused. “You seem nervous,” he said. His voice purred, vibrating in her own chest, stirring up her insides like he was licking her -

Hannah shook her head. Then she blushed. Then she shrugged and looked down at a small drinks card that she had either placed there herself, or Gus had. “Okay,” she said. “I am. A little. Nervous.”

A waitress, dressed in all black, thin as a rail and with a rubbery body type, bent her knees to set a glass down on the table. She eyed Hannah suspiciously and then fished a drink from her over-stuffed tray, setting it down at the exact center of the table.

Gus looked up at her. “Stop by, if you will, darlin’, in case she wants something else.”

He looked at Hannah. “It’s a gin and tonic,” he said.

She had ordered one on the plane.

She reached for it, trying to make it look like it was a concession of some kind, though she felt like downing three of them in succession.

Luckily for her, Gus plunged right in.

“You’re nervous because of the whole plane thing. What was it? ‘Planebae2?’”

Hannah gulped the drink. “Partly,” she said, aware of a drop of gin on her upper lip. Should she lick it? She kind of had to. She looked at the wall as she did. She didn’t need to give him any ideas.

“It’s just internet garbage,” Gus said. “Everyone forgot about it two weeks ago.”

Hannah smiled. She inhaled. “It’s not just that,” she said.

“Mmm,” August said, leaning back, folding his arms as though he’d just scored some kind of point.

“What’s that mean, ‘mmm?’” Hannah shot at him. She was relieved that her anger at his cockiness was getting the upper hand again.

He grinned. “Oh, I get it,” he said. “It’s that you’re married.”

Hannah squinted at him. “Maybe.”

“And you’re here.”

She gave him a look.

He leaned forward, on his arms, his eyes taking another walk up and down her outfit. “Which brings us to the question, Mrs. Moore. Why *are* you nervous about being here?”

Hannah was pissed off, on the one hand, and her temper flared inside of her. Her face got hot, she could feel it, and she hoped it didn’t show.

On the other hand, she was transfixed, and her chest was full of fluttering shards of glass, and her pussy was dripping wet and throbbing. He was right there, his dry warm lips just inches from her own, and she should probably have slapped him, but instead she pictured his mouth getting closer, even closer....

She leaned back. “*You’re* pretty sure you’ve got it all figured out,” she scolded.

August smiled. He didn’t retreat. In fact, he might have moved even closer, for all she knew. Then he leaned back, smiling. “I’m just here for dinner with a friend,” he said.

The waitress was coming back. Hannah’s eyes fell to her drink, which was almost empty.

“Two more,” August said, and she thought of protesting, but didn’t.

He leaned in again, and she edged close on the small, round glass table. Her knees touched his, but there was no remedy for that, was there? The air might as well have been boiling between them. She edged her glass

closer to herself, looking at it with determination, trying not to let her eyes focus through the glass at his muscular thighs, or even further toward...

"Hey," August said, and his voice was soft. Charming. Such a snake charmer, Hannah thought, even as the charm traveled all over her body and into her scalp.

God.

She played with the straw in her drink.

"Let's not fight," August said. "Let's just have a nice drink. And then... whatever happens, happens."

"Nothing's going to happen," she said quickly.

"I'm fine with that," he said, bringing his drink to his lips. The shake of the ice in his glass whispered: *like that's really what you want.*

"Okay," she said. "Just had to get that on the table."

"Okay," August said. "We'll just have a few drinks, some tapas to sober you up, and you'll go home."

Hannah nodded. "Okay."

"Okay."

What happened?

She had too many drinks, that was the first thing. They just kept appearing at the table, and by the time she had the sense to cut herself off, she was already drunk and it was already evident that she was going to have to call her husband and tell him she wasn't going home.

It was just a question of what she was going to say.

"Ohhhhh," she had slurred, smiling at August, "I can't possibly drive home."

"That's too bad," he had said, disingenuously.

"What am I going to say to Mike?"

August smiled. "Not the truth."

The conversation had moved on from there.

If Hannah was being fair, he wasn't the world's greatest conversationalist. It was *fun* talking to him, it was *fun* edging her knees closer to his, pretending to be sorry for bumping him, linking her arm in his as they walked to a restaurant to get Indian food. He was a fun guy, an outdoorsy guy, a really *hot* guy.

But he was candy, not a meal.

It was fun running into his friends, two guys who gave her looks of approval and him a thumbs-up when they thought she couldn't see, fun being in the city full of lights and people and feeling like the tether of her life had been cut free.

Except it hadn't.

"Jesus," she said, outside of the Indian restaurant. She was quite drunk, she realized, and a quick calculation – four drinks – made it perfectly clear why. She dropped her phone, and Gus laughed, picking it up. "You need some tea or something," he told her.

"What am I going to tell Mike?" she asked him. Over drinks, she felt like she had built an odd kind of rapport with him: he'd still try to get her to bed, and she'd still let him think it was possible until the last minute, and her body was enjoying the thrill of it like a hot soak in a tub. But she was talking openly about her husband to him now, and how she had to get home, and making it clear she wasn't going to start some affair with him.

"You have a friend or anything, in the city?" Gus asked.

She did. She had one friend who might fit the bill, but if she had run into her, she would have texted Mike earlier. The story wasn't going to make sense now. It was almost seven o'clock.

She had an idea. It was devious, it was horrible, it was a lie, and it would trap her here all night, but just because she was here did *not* mean she was obligated to sleep with Gus Healy.

She typed, her fingers fat and drunken, and Gus leaned over her shoulder, so she pushed him away playfully. "And this does *not* mean anything is going to happen here, okay?" she said.

"Tests, running a long time?" he said, grinning. "That's a good one. Are they going to take all night?"

She held up her hand. "Just... I have a plan, okay?"

She was so drunk. She was making terrible decisions. But what else could she do? She couldn't drive home, she couldn't take the risk of losing her license, her job, everything. She couldn't very well just text Mike and tell him she had too many drinks with Gus and she was going to sleep on his couch, could she?

She stared at her text.

[Me]: *This is taking forever. Still not done. I'm going to call Annie and see if I can get dinner with her and crash*

on her couch if that's okay.

She squinted at it, deleted the part about Annie, and added several angry emoticons. She would text about Annie later, when she was even more fed up with the hour. Maybe Mike would even *suggest* that she stay overnight.

She added one last thing to her text.

[Me]: This is taking forever. Still not done. So bored and tired zzzzzzzzzZZZZZZZ

“Okay,” she said, looking up at Gus, who raised his eyebrows. She dropped her phone into her purse.

Then she reached for his arm, and his muscles were hard and hot beneath her palm. “Don’t let me forget to follow up on this,” she said, drunkenly.

Gus swung the door open for her. “Can-do,” he assured her.

“Well,” August said, pouring another glass of water for her. “I think you’re a little sobered up, but not good enough to drive.”

Hannah shook her head, agreeing with that statement.

“So... since you’re determined that nothing is going to happen tonight.” He moved his fingers, pointing from his chest to hers and back again, still smiling his cocksure smile. “May I suggest we go have some fun?”

Fun.

Fun was something Hannah never got to have. The idea of fun – especially this sizzling, illicit fun she was having now – ignited her.

So they went, to have fun.

Gus paid the bill, and Hannah realized that the one glass of wine she had consumed had not, by some miracle, counteracted the four gin and tonics she’d had earlier. She was still flying, and she knew better than to drink any more.

Or so she told herself as she left the restaurant.

They took a cab, and the air boiled between them as they rode through the downtown core, lights sliding off the chrome, music seeping through the cracks of the cab, the excited feel of the city all around her. Gus

was looking at her the whole time, and she alternated between looking ahead, smiling for him, and then glancing over at him to find him still looking at her. She rolled her eyes when she met his.

“Nothing,” she kept mouthing. *Nothing is going to happen between us.*

At this point, she was certain she didn’t believe that herself, but she was enjoying the guilt-free-ish plane between admitting her transgressions to herself and actually putting a stop to them. There, she was floating, high on drinks, lights, and laughter, riding in a cab, going somewhere, doing something.

Being *bad*.

It was *fun*, potent, adrenaline-inducing, whirling *fun*.

They twisted and turned through the city, and she was somewhere she was no longer familiar with. When the cab stopped, they got out and joined a line. The people around them were young, and for a moment Hannah had a stab of feeling too old. She grasped Gus by the hand to pull him out of the line. “I have a sweater on,” she whispered to him, smiling, feeling dizzy. If she was pulling him out of line for the club, where was she thinking they would go instead? His place? Somewhere more intimate?

The feeling that she had made a very bad choice was ballooning inside of her; she had a sudden desire to get back in the cab they’d come in, to go back to where her car was parked (where *was* her car parked?) and sleep in the backseat until she could get home. Or maybe really call Annie.

Gus was smiling, pulling her back into the line. “You look fine,” he insisted. “But you’re going to be hot if you dance.”

Hannah wanted to tell him *that* wasn’t going to happen, but the idea of standing next to him in the dark, the alternating flashes of lights swirling around them, the music so loud it could cover up anything they did...

“What do you have on under it?” he asked.

Hannah felt a flash of shame spread across the back of her neck. In the end, she’d put on a pair of lacy black underwear, a matching set. And then, when her sweater had itched, she had put on a silk camisole.

She looked around at the girls waiting in line. Did she dare strip down to her camisole? It was technically underwear, but she would have said the same thing about fifty percent of what she saw on display in this line.

She pulled her sweater up to show Gus the camisole.

He shrugged. “Perfect.”

CHAPTER 10

Mike had Gosia stay late, for an incredibly large sum of money, while he tried to get his head on straight by pacing in his office until about 8:00.

His stomach was in knots, a coiled energy that just kept getting more tight was twisting inside of him, and he felt like he needed to crawl out of his skin.

He knew Hannah was lying to him. He had known it since the bedroom, known it all along, since she had mentioned her doctor's appointment. He even *wanted* her to be lying, and he wanted to tell her to just go ahead, go into the city and see August Healy, and then tell him about every gut-wrenching sordid detail.

So why was she still lying to him?

He received her text at 6 pm, which was far, far too long for any tests to have taken. He had answered her:

[Me]: *Oh no. What's taking so long? Give me a call.*

And then he had received nothing at all for hours, while he fumed in his office and thought of the worst scenarios he could bring himself to imagine: that this thing with Gus would become a regular thing, and he would be sitting at home alone, staring out the window, thinking about how his wife was in the city, her legs spread over another guy's hips, riding him like a cowgirl.

He waited it out, grateful that the kids were happily dialed into their electronics, old enough not to need anything from him, so that he could brood in peace and quiet while he waited to hear from his wife.

He wondered if she had worn that ratty underwear in the end. It was only the underwear that made him think there was a *chance* that she wasn't going to town to fuck August Healy.

Thinking this, he had slammed his drink on the glass table in the office so hard it cracked the glass top over the desk, which was already cracked and hardly mattered, but still. Walking briskly, heart pounding, he had stormed into the closet, where the wicker laundry basket was propped in a corner. It was overflowing with dirty laundry, almost laundry day. A

few shirts were strewn over the top of the basket, but just below the surface, he found them: the off-white underwear she had been wearing earlier in the day.

The acrid scent of his own cum floated to his nostrils, resting on a pillow of tangy sweetness that was his wife's excitement.

Of course she had changed them, he thought to himself. He had fucked her, and she was dripping *his* cum everywhere. Her changing her underwear proved nothing.

He clutched them in his hand, and the cool sensation of betrayal grew in his belly anyway. His cock was thickening, he felt sick every time he let his thoughts wander to his wife's body. Where was she now, what was she wearing against her skin? Or had she already taken it all off?

Around nine pm he got a text, decidedly garbled, obviously drunk, and very suspicious:

[Hannah]: *imgo ind g to call Anni and stay here. Its so lat ed.*

Annie.

His stomach plunged through his feet again, and his heart rate sped up. It could be true, it could all be true: his wife could be in the city, taking a really long time with tests (what tests? What could possibly require three hours of testing?) and now too tired to come home. Staying with a friend. A female, older, non-sexy friend.

It could all be legitimate.

He laughed under his breath. *Right.*

Now, more than ever, he felt a new twist on his desires: he wanted to catch her. Not only did he want her to be lying to him, not only did he want her to be fucking him right now, he wanted to *catch* her doing it.

It was perverse, but it was how he felt. His cock was fully erect now: if she had been around, he would have fucked his cum into her in three seconds flat. But instead, maybe August Healy was doing just that, bouncing her on top of his lap so that she couldn't type straight. He pictured her putting her hand on August's shoulder, her skin wet with his sweat, her breath uneven and ragged. "Wait," she would say, shifting her weight on his cock, closing her eyes as the tip of it touched some new and different place inside of her, somewhere deep where Mike's own cock never reached. She

would catch her breath for a moment, her pussy pulsing with the desire to come, but she would wait.

“Wait while I send him a message,” she would say, a tiny bead of sweat on her upper lip. She would type, and August would lift her hips slowly, massaging his shaft with her slick wet pussy while she wrote to her husband:

imgo ind g to call Anni and stay here. Its so lat ed.

Mike pictured her sending the message, pushing her loose hair from her face, the sweat helping to slick it back a little. Her breasts were bobbing in front of August’s face, his tongue flicking out to play with her nipples.

“Oh my God,” she would laugh. “What did I just... write...?”

But she would lose her train of thought as he began to bounce her, first slowly, his cock penetrating deep inside of her, touching all those forbidden places. And then faster, and faster, until her skin was slapping violently against the top of his thighs, wet and sticky, while she leaned her head back and mewled loudly. She would come like a rocket, sitting on his lap, and her juices would drip down to his thighs while her breasts heaved in front of his face. He would push her firm little pillows into his own face while he shot his seed deep inside of her, filling her pussy to the brim with his hot, white cum.

Mike sank into a chair, one hand holding the phone, the other working his belt open, searching for his cock. His eyes were on the screen, waiting for her reply, waiting while his mind filled with images of all the very bad things she was doing right now.

He started to jerk off, and the fantasy mutated: he pictured her coming home, the look of guilt on her face. He would just tell her to her face that she was caught, that he wasn’t born yesterday, and that she had to make it up to him. And then he would fill her cheating mouth with his cock, and she would look up at him with guilt in her eyes... and then he would fuck his own cum into her cheating pussy, sloshing around in her loose folds, mixing his cum with her lover’s, while he made her tell him every detail of the way August Healy had used her body like blow-up rubber doll...

He came as soon as he had that very thought, and placed his hands on the desk, panting, still waiting, a feeling of guilt dripping through his body like slowly poured paint.

It was gone in no time, as he stared at the phone, and his wife's lies, a little longer.

He picked it up, and without much hesitation or much of a plan, he pressed on her icon, calling her.

He hadn't expected her to answer, so it was not until the message picked up that he realized he needed to say something.

And almost like an epiphany, he knew what it was.

"Hannah," he said, and his voice sounded firmer to him than it ever had before. "I know you're with August Healy. And I want you to call me back."

He hung up the phone.

Well, he thought, and an almost mirthful smile pushed at the corners of his mouth. He was 97% sure she was with August Healy, so he was 97% he was on his way to getting something he wanted, and looking like a badass while he did it.

But if she wasn't...

Well, then. He probably looked like a huge jackass.

But then his wife wasn't cheating on him.

He leaned back in his chair.

What kind of man was he, that he honestly preferred the first choice?

CHAPTER 11

The wait outside the club could have been five minutes, and it could have been an hour. She didn't know, by the time they were crossing through the doorway. August grabbed her hand to pull her through the crowd. They had talked very little, exchanging instead a sort of raw animal heat while they waited.

Inside it was hot, and humid, and both of those things seemed to radiate from the squirming, writhing, beautiful human bodies that Hannah glimpsed as they made their way through the crowd. People they passed seemed to know August, and girls gave her a look up and down, one that Hannah recognized as girl-hostile. It only twisted her up further inside: these girls were all young, and they were looking at her like she was a threat, competition. It was flattering. She couldn't help getting high on it.

She had a drink at the bar with August, where she took off her sweater. August had taken an approving walk over her body once she was free of it.

Then he said something, and she couldn't hear him, so she shook her head. He had leaned close to her, gently pulling her forward to him with two fingers tantalizingly resting on her jawline. "You look hot," he had breathed into her ear, his breath stroking her earlobe and her neck, raising her hair, traveling through her again to end with a pleasurable pulse in her pussy. As he leaned back, his fingertips enclosed momentarily on her loose hair.

Hannah shuddered, as though a chill had gone through the club.

She brought her drink to her mouth as August had turned to talk to someone who had tapped him on the shoulder.

She was already thinking, or getting around to thinking (her thoughts were moving too quickly to be clear, or so slowly they made no sense) that she needed to put the brakes on all of this, when her phone buzzed in her back pocket, and a stab of fear traveled through her: *she had forgotten to get back to Mike.*

The horror only deepened when she saw that he was calling. And that she had missed a text message from him, from almost an hour ago, asking her to call him back.

It was also ten o'clock. Too late. Far too late to claim to still be getting tests done, or trying to reach Annie.

She put a hand on August's forearm. The full power of her drunkenness set in on her like a fog off the sea: she was suddenly wasted. "I have to go to the ladies," she said shakily.

August smiled at her, and then before she could step away, he grasped her hand and squeezed it. Again his mouth was close to her neck, and she was powerless to stop him. "Don't get lost," he said. "You still owe me a dance."

Hannah smiled. The whirling fun she had been having only moments ago was crashing down around her. Shit. Shit, shit, shit. What had she been thinking?

She pushed her way to the bathroom, pissing off a lot of girls as she did. There was a long line, and she stared at her phone as she waited. She had half a mind to just get in a cab, now, and go home. How much would a cab be from here to Redville? What would she say when she got home?

She finally reached the front of the line, and then tucked herself into a stall. The bathroom was remarkably clean, and luxurious. It was a long way from the clubs *she* used to go to, what seemed like a whole lifetime ago, stained with grotesque graffiti and God-knows-what else.

A thick door went almost to the floor and cut out most of the noise. She called her voicemail.

Each syllable of her husband's voice cut through her like a knife, almost as though time had been slowed, each word lengthened to hours.

Hannah.

I know

you're

with

August

Healy.

And I want

you

to

call

me

back.

His voice was different than she had ever heard. There was no lying to this voice anymore: he *knew*.

Of course he knew.

It seemed suddenly so preposterous to her that she had even entertained the idea that he *didn't know*, that in spite of how guilty and terrible she felt, she almost had to laugh at herself.

The door rattled. "Hey," a girl said bitterly. "Some of us gotta pee."

"Sorry," Hannah said. "I just – just a minute."

She was hot at the neck, her camisole getting wet with the sweat that was oozing from her skin. A guilty, hot sheen over her whole body.

Her fingers trembled. She stared at the phone.

Outside the stall, there was a lively discussion erupting, the topic of which Hannah could not have picked out for a million dollars.

She couldn't call him from here.

But if not here, where?

Her finger, almost as if it were acting on its own, pressed down on the call button. She could hear the dull ring of the phone under the noise of the bathroom. She wanted to hang up, she wanted to hang up more than anything. But she couldn't.

She brought the phone to her ear, and her face felt cool when her knuckles brushed against it. Her heart was either beating too quickly or too slowly to get her blood moving; she felt thick, as though moving through water.

"Where are you?" Mike said, when he answered.

Hannah's voice cracked when she opened her mouth. She could feel tears welling up in her eyes. She had six million things she wanted to say, but couldn't organize any of them.

"I'm..." she tried to say, but a sob – and Hannah was not the crying type – caught her in the back of the throat, scraping her skin, making it instantly sore. She sniffed, and leaned her head back to keep her tears from rolling down her face.

"Why did you lie to me, Hannah?" he said.

She sniffed again. "I don't know."

"You're there now, with him?"

She nodded, and then remembered that she was on the phone. "Yeah."

"Where?"

She gave him the best directions she could, thinking, absurdly, that he was going to say next that he would come and get her. "Some club.. in... Southie, or, I don't know, maybe Cabbagetown. It's called Bare Cat or something.. I don't have the address."

There was silence. "What have you done so far with him?"

Mike's voice was strange, she thought. She tried to place his emotion, and her stomach felt odd as she found herself entertaining the idea again that maybe he *had* been serious when he had suggested that she have an affair.

"Hannah?"

"I... I haven't done anything with him," she said. She wiped her nose. Okay, so that was true. It was true she was here, and it was true she had thought about it, but it was also true that as far as actually cheating on her husband went, she hadn't done it.

She started to say this. "Mike, I'm sorry," she whispered. "I really just came for -"

"So you haven't kissed him. Or anything."

She stopped mid-sentence. "I... what? No."

"Nothing."

She narrowed her eyes. "No. And I... I never meant to, I just -"

"Hannah?" Mike interrupted.

She stared at the slats in the door. She sniffed again. "What?"

Her heart sank, her whole body felt leaden with dread.

"I want you to do it."

Her eyes went wide.

"What?" she said. She clutched the phone. "What?"

There was a long pause, and she was about to ask "what?" again, when Mike cleared his throat. "Do you remember when I talked to you about this, back when the reporter called you?"

"I... yes, but what...?"

"I want you to go ahead and do something with him, Hannah. Whatever you were planning on doing. I want you to do it."

Hannah's body went cold.

Was she hearing what she thought she was hearing?

"What?" she repeated.

"Do it. Go ahead and have an affair with him. You're already halfway there. The only deal is that you have to tell me everything you do -"

“What are you saying?” Hannah said in disbelief.

“Every. Single. Detail. You have to tell me all the details whenever I want to hear them.”

Hannah’s mouth was open. She couldn’t believe this was Mike. The person on the other end sounded so unlike Mike, in fact, that she pulled the phone away from her ear and looked blankly at the number to confirm she was talking to him.

Also, she was getting turned on by this talk for some reason.

Turned on – almost as much as by Gus, if not more – by the idea of doing one illicit thing (“whatever you were going to do” with Gus), and then doing an even more crazy, illicit thing with her husband. (Telling him about it. Especially if he talked to her like that.)

“You aren’t serious,” she whispered.

Mike said nothing.

“Are you?”

“I’m serious. You’re already halfway there, Hannah. So now... go ahead and see where it takes you. But the catch is, you have to tell me all about it.”

Hannah’s heart fluttered. “Why?” she said.

The prospect of what he was laying on the table was too good to be true, and she didn’t trust it: could she actually do something with Gus, *with* her husband’s blessing?

It couldn’t be real.

“I’ll talk to you about it later. Just... you have my permission to do it. I want you to do it.”

There was a pause while the thumping of the music pulsed around her. “I just want you to tell me about it,” he added.

The walls swam in front of her. “I don’t think I can... do that,” Hannah said.

“Tell me about it?”

She shook her head. Someone started banging on the bathroom door again. “No, just do it,” she said quickly. “I mean... this is...”

What? This was what?

She was horribly confused. Energy pulled her two different ways: on the one hand, the evening was picking up again, threatening to spin wildly out of control, in delicious, fun ways. On the other, the evening was

deflating, losing control in another, darker way that made her want to go home, right now.

"Well," Mike said. "You're there. You can't get home tonight. So... why don't you just see where it takes you?"

See where it takes you.

"Mike," she said.

"Honey. I love you," he said.

"I don't want to do... anything that will – I feel like we need to talk about this more."

Mike was silent.

"I don't want to hurt you," she said.

Mike's voice was resolute. "Hannah. We both knew why you were going into the city today. I let it happen. You let it happen. Now I'm telling you, just see where it takes you."

Her heart felt like it was turning inside out.

"Mike -"

"Are you attracted to him?"

She swallowed. "I guess so."

"Do you love him?"

She stared at the slats in front of her. *God, no*, she thought. "I love you," she said. "This was all a mistake, I realize that now -"

"That's all I wanted to know. So then everything is fine. See where it takes you."

The door shook again. "Jesus, lady, what are you doing in there?"

Hannah smashed her hand on the door, losing her cool for a moment. "Just a goddamn minute," she said, using her bossiest voice, which seemed to do the trick because whoever was on the other side backed right off.

"Sounds like you'd better go."

"Mike..." she said.

"Where is he now?"

She looked around, as if the answer would be in the bathroom.

"Outside. In the club, I mean."

"What are you wearing?"

She looked down at herself. "I'm..." What the hell was he asking her? "A camisole. Jeans."

"I saw you ditched your crappy underwear. What did you wear instead?"

Her chest contracted. It felt like a dragon was licking at the insides of her body as she answered:

“A black pair. Satin with lace. Matching.”

There was a long pause while she waited, heating up, for his voice on the other end. “I bet you look hot. Maybe you can get a picture for me.”

Hannah caught her breath.

“I want *all* the details,” Mike said, and his breath was raspy. “I’ll see you tomorrow.”

It took her a while to realize the phone had gone dead, and that he was no longer on the line.

Hannah fumbled with the door, brushed past the waiting girls, who gave her dirty looks as she exited, and was back in the club with her head spinning.

As she rounded the edge of the dance floor, Mike’s voice filled her head, almost on beat with the music. Her insides were on fire, her body ripped in two. She met Gus’s eyes: he was taller than almost everyone, and it was almost like a scene from a movie, where the whole crowd blended away into a blur of noise and shimmering, fleshy extras.

Now her skin started tingle, and she glided through the crowd, as if pulled by a tractor beam toward him. *See where it takes you.*

August slid a drink to her at the bar, and leaned toward her again. “Everything all right?”

Her camisole was low on her front, caught there by the sweat that coated her body. Her thoughts scattered, his breath played with the fine hairs on her neck, and an electric tingle ran the length of her spine, plucked at her insides, made her pussy throb.

Tell me every detail.

She took the drink, and swallowed it quickly. She thought about telling Gus that her husband had just told her to sleep with him, and then, when she saw the satisfied look of a hunter in his eyes, changed her mind.

She leaned toward him, inhaled the musky scent of his body. His deodorant, the smell of his skin, clean and masculine. “Fine,” she said, and was glad that the music was covering up the shakiness in her voice. “I’m going to go dance.”

CHAPTER 12

He spoke to her around ten-thirty, and then sank into an armchair, his blood boiling, every scenario he could imagine filling his mind, draining like a pool, and then filling again. It sometimes occurred to him to write back to her, to call her, to put a stop to what he had just set in motion.

But he didn't.

The hours ticked away he sat in the uncomfortable decorative armchair in their bedroom. His gut blossomed with aches of longing, raw sexual desire, cold jealousy, and intense arousal. He pictured all of the scenarios that could be happening, right then, between his wife and August Healy. Romantic, passionate scenarios. Feral, wild fucking. He imagined his wife crying guiltily as Gus fucked his cum into her, and he imagined his wife converting to a filthy and remorseless slut.

He masturbated, lay in bed, inhaled the scent of his wife from her pillow and her side of the bed. It was funny how married couples inevitably ended up with a "side" to their bed. Why was that?

His heart caved in on itself as he realized that the familiarity of their marriage was forever changed: the wife who would come back to him after tonight would not be his and his alone. Someone else could feel her thighs around his waist right now, someone else knew what her cunt tasted like, someone else would feel the shudder of her limbs when she came.

And her side of the bed would not be the same ever again.

He fell asleep at some point, and one of those terrible lucid dreams generated in his mind. In the dream, his cellphone rang next to him on the bed. It was Hannah's number. He sleepily brought it to his ear. In the dream he was exhausted, he could barely answer the phone or manage to speak through his grogginess. Hannah's voice came through the speaker in his ear, as clear as though she were right next to him. At first, it was only a series of sharp breaths, grunts, and mewls. The sounds Hannah made when she was being fucked. Then: "Oh! Oh! Oh! Your cock feels so good, I want it deeper inside of me."

"Hannah?" he had managed to say into the phone.

And then she had laughed, and the grunting continued. "Mike," she said breathlessly. "It's my husband..." and then he had realized in the dream

that she was talking to Gus, not to him. “Hold on, I have to tell him I’m going to be late. Don’t, don’t make me come, don’t lick me there, I won’t... be able... to talk to him...”

“Hannah!” he had said sharply.

“I’m going... to be late...” she had hoarsely moaned. But her final words were swallowed up in a guttural mewl as she came, and dropped the phone next to her. He listened as August Healy fucked his wife again and again, slapping her ass, making her howl, calling her a dirty slut in amazement as she performed God-only-knows-what tricks on his cock.

In the dream, he tried to masturbate as he listened, but he could never make himself come.

He woke up in a sweat, his cock painfully hard, his balls aching. He relieved himself of the built-up cum, but his mind was still as painfully full as his balls had been just moments before.

He watched the light change, from black to inky blue, until the ceiling grew white and he heard the kids upstairs. He was grateful for the distraction of making breakfast, acting normal for a few moments.

They were happy to be packed off to their friends’ houses for an overnight stay the next morning. It left Mike with the whole day to pace and ponder what had happened with his wife and August Healy, his insides turning over like an endless tide, dragging his organs along the bottom. He was sour and then elated, cold and then hot. He sent Hannah a single message (when are you coming home?) and waited in agony until she responded. A single line of text, its emotional timbre unreadable:

[Hannah]: *Leaving now*

And so he was left to wait.

*

Hannah let the door close and leaned against it. Her face was pale: traces of mascara had rubbed off beneath her eyes. Mike’s gut twisted as he wondered if it had streaked down her face when she sucked August’s cock, or if it was sweat that had sent it smearing on her cheeks when she was on top of him, riding him, gasping for air as she came hard and spilled her juices onto his balls.

Her sweater looked stretched, but perhaps he was only thinking of her pussy. It hung off one shoulder more than the other, exposing her neck, where a red splotch indicated that something had rubbed on her. Lips? Teeth? A column of meat, topped by a pearly bead of precum? His cock pulsed, as he thought about what else was distended, swollen, marked, beneath his wife's sweater.

She had a hard time looking him in the eye.

Her own gaze traveled around the house, scanning.

"The kids are gone," he said. *So you can tell me whatever you want.*
"Did you do it?"

Hannah looked different somehow. Something in her expression was foreign. He realized as he was looking at her that – for perhaps the first time in their marriage - Hannah had the expression of a person hiding a secret, weighing how much of it to divulge.

But what was the secret? His chest was tight as his heart almost burst through his sternum, aching to know. Would she give him everything she had promised to give him, or would she only tell him what she thought he wanted to hear?

Hannah leaned back against the door. It was almost like she was deciding whether or not to enter the house, to re-enter their marriage.

Or was he making himself crazy? He wanted to grab her, shake her, shake the details and the truth out of her as fast as he could. But at the same time, he had a feeling it was best to wait, to let Hannah delve it out. Whatever it was.

"You really want to hear all about it?" she said. Her eyes were reading him carefully.

"I told you I did," he replied. His voice was shaking in his throat, mimicking his rapid, uneven pulse. He couldn't pinpoint the source of the shakiness: excitement or fury, fear or anticipation?

Hannah stepped toward him, pulling at the sleeves of her sweater until they slid past her wrists. She pulled the clingy cashmere from her body with a static crinkle.

The black satin camisole she was wearing beneath the sweater stuck to her skin with static. It was loose, and one spaghetti shoulder strap slid off making the satin just above her breasts drop slightly. The crevice between her breasts was visible, the light lace of her bra peeking out from the plunge of the camisole. Her hair got even more tousled from peeling off the

sweater, like she had just been freshly fucked on her back and hurried to put her clothes on before she got caught.

She had black, heeled boots on, lengthening her legs and toning them within the tight jeans. There was a gap between the camisole and the waist of her jeans, where he could see a sliver of her smooth navel. Her green eyes glinted from behind the smeared black mascara. "This is what I wore to the club last night," she said. Her voice seemed husky, probably from lack of sleep.

He sucked in his breath, unable to articulate anything more as she walked toward him, her heels clicking solidly on the wood floor.

He was standing behind the counter, much like he had been when she had returned home from Denver. Only now, the woman in front of him looked ethereal, like a sex kitten, like an expensive hooker, and not like his wife.

His chest felt cold. She leaned on the counter, the camisole falling to give him a nice view of her breasts. "What do you think?" she asked.

"About... about what?" he said, mesmerized. He really couldn't remember the conversation that well up to here, if any conversation had been had. He was staring at the lace cupping her breasts, wondering how her lover had unwrapped her from all of that packaging.

He had moved closer to the counter, and discovered that his fingers were already reaching for her, pulling lazily at the edge of her bra, his eyes looking hungrily into the shadows against her skin for something out of place, some evidence that August had been there.

Hannah smiled, and lifted a hand to grasp his, moving it up to her lips. She kissed his fingertips, sucking on the end of his ring finger. It was then that he noticed her wedding ring on her left hand, something he hadn't looked at for a long time. He had never even considered the ring, whether she would wear it while she did whatever she had done with August, but an image of her hand around another man's cock, the small diamond glinting against his swollen member, made him take another sharp inhale.

He pressed his fingertips to her lips, drawing her lower lip down slightly as he moved down her chin, her neck, and back to her breasts. He slipped a finger beneath the bra, searching for her right nipple, finding it pebbled and expectant.

Heat simmered between them, Hannah's mouth was still open slightly.

“Tell me what happened,” he said.

Hannah blushed briefly, which only incensed him more. Her eyes dropped, he squeezed her nipple. “What did you do at the club?”

“I danced with him for a while,” she said.

He moved his hand over her breasts. “More detail,” he managed to say, and enjoyed the way Hannah’s skin heated up. Her throat pulsed. “We danced close. Really close.”

He dropped his hand, moving around the counter to where she was. “Face to face? Or how?” He pushed her hair from her face, and moved his lips close to hers, so that he could almost taste them. Would they be salty, from sweat and cum? He let his mouth linger there as Hannah’s body molded to his.

“A little bit of both,” Hannah said. She put her hands on his hips and pulled him close to her, so her breasts were against his chest, her fingers moving at the button of his pants, tugging at his shirt. “Close like this, and then sometimes like this,” she said, turning and replacing her hands on his hips, her bottom snug in his crotch, his cock hard against her. She looked over her shoulder, her hair falling forward, her neck bare to his lips. “Except he’s taller than you,” she said. “So his cock was against me right here.”

He looked down to see her finger sliding along the highest part of her bottom, along the waist of her jeans. His own cock pulsed, and she smiled.

She turned around, moving her arms to hang on his shoulders, grinding against him. She was getting into it, he could see her sinking into the role of temptress, of slut, of cheating wife. His heart trilled, his blood turned hot.

Their lips were close for a moment, just millimeters between them, her eyes green and mischievous in front of his. He couldn't wait any longer, he enclosed her mouth with his, tasting her lips first, then exploring the hot inside. Her tongue darted against his, and he had a brief thought that she kissed differently – though how long had it been since they kissed like this?

A faint taste of alcohol lingered on her lips, something salty, and a minty flavor that could have been toothpaste or gum.

The heat between them flared, and he lifted her up and pulled her legs around his waist. He could feel the shape of her pubic bone and the soft mound beneath it against him as he held her thighs and walked her toward the hallway.

Hannah's fingers moved over the back of his neck, sending a shudder along his spine. She kissed him as he walked her backward, and then let her lips brush over his along with her breath as she whispered:

"We kissed just like that at the club."

An almost painful surge made his cock flex, and Hannah smiled. Each time she said something that made him react that way, she seemed to physically gain power, and he could see that it thrilled her. He couldn't make it all the way to the bedroom, so he veered toward the living room.

He had to stop and push her against the wall, as much a question of strength as it was his desire. He pushed his cock against her mound, and burrowed his hand into her pants. He found her pussy, the trim feathery hair sticky and wet, the lips soaked. He thrust his tongue into her mouth as his fingers explored the wet petals of her cunt.

He bit her lower lip as he pulled away from her mouth. He was sliding his hand from her jeans. "Did you shower before you came home?"

Hannah ordinarily would have lost it with a question like that, but this woman was not the same Hannah who had left the house yesterday. Her eyes glinted and she said, in her throaty, tired voice:

"What do you think?"

He pulled his hand from her jeans and brought it up to his nose. Her pussy was sweet, often citrusy, a little tart, and he could smell her familiar scent. But there was something else there, lingering: a bleachy, musky scent.

Another man's cum.

His cock pulsed again, and the sexual heat of it radiated into his entire abdomen.

Hannah leaned forward, and enclosed his fingers in her mouth, her eyes on his.

He lost it, swinging her away from the wall, a new energy pulsing inside of him that made her body feel feather-light. He tossed her onto the couch and she grinned at him as she unbuttoned her pants before he had even said aloud: "Take your jeans off. And your panties."

She shimmied from the tight jeans, and he reached down to help peel them from her legs. He could smell both the fresh wet scent of her, and the dried leftovers that were crusted on her underwear. When he reached to the center of the satin panties, he felt the hardened rivets of dried cum and

pussy juices, now being slowly softened by the hot juices dripping from inside of her.

He tore them away, and Hannah looked pleasantly shocked by his aggressiveness.

“Did you suck his cock?” he asked her.

Hannah was on her elbows, and she looked at him temptingly, her legs falling open to show him her soaked pussy, the reddened lips, the raw skin that had clearly rubbed and rubbed against August’s balls and pelvis. She playfully trailed her fingers down her navel, briefly over her pussy, and then to her thigh.

Mike’s eyes went to her lips as she licked them, her pink tongue trailing along her upper lip, her eyes on his. “I did. I did it after he fucked me.”

She never talked like this; he would have been the last person in the world to think that Hannah had it in her to say the things she was saying, or that her eyes would gleam so much as she built up momentum.

When she saw his reaction, it seemed to ignite her, give her an idea. “Maybe you should fuck your cum into me, and then I can suck your cock clean.”

He was breathing heavily, he felt like he couldn’t get enough air, or even move. He was trying to say something, something about her mouth, when Hannah took the words right from him:

“Then I’ll have a very, very dirty mouth.”

“Fuck,” he whispered instead. Who the hell was this woman?

But it didn’t matter. Her legs were spread and her pussy was full of her own juices, and another man’s cum. He could see the opaque, milky evidence of it welling up from inside her.

“Where did you fuck him?” he breathed, getting out of his own pants as fast as he could. He was staring at his wife’s used pussy, her fingers strolling along her thighs absently. Her mouth was curled up in a grin.

“At his apartment. Twice.”

He put his hands on her ankles and pushed her legs up to his shoulders as he crawled onto the couch on his knees. Her pussy was just inches from his cock, her body supple beneath him, the scent of her pussy rising up between them. “Did he have a big cock?” he asked her.

Hannah’s mouth moved involuntarily, turning upward. He *did* have a big cock, and she didn’t even have to say the words. But Hannah was

clearly having fun now; she smiled before she spoke. "It was really, really thick," she whispered. "And so long, I didn't think I'd be able to take it all."

He thrust inside of her, and her flexible thighs easily yielded, so her legs were by her ears. She gasped, and her eyes rolled a little in pleasure. Her pussy massaged him in waves. He tried to figure out if she was looser, but her cunt felt tight around his cock, just sloshy enough that there was almost no friction.

Which was good, because he was going to come in a few seconds if she didn't stop squirming.

He put a hand in her hair and growled in her ear. "Stop moving, and tell me more about his cock in your pussy."

"He got it all in," Hannah breathed, smiling, twisting her hips a little before she squeezed him with her legs and tried to stay still. Her pussy was throbbing, clearly outside of her control, and he could hardly see straight for trying to hold back his own deluge. "He finally got it in and then I could feel his balls on my ass." She had her fingers in Mike's hair, and pulled her face close to his again. "He fucked me just like you're fucking me now, only up against a wall. And harder."

She moved beneath him, and he grasped her legs and began to slam his cock inside of her. If she liked being fucked hard, he could do that.

He was relieved when Hannah began to mewl, and her hips ground harder against him. He could feel her muscles clamping down on his cock. Her eyes closed as her pussy squeezed and then seemed to explode into a honeyed liquid. He let himself go after a few thrusts, filling her already overflowing, cheating pussy with his cum.

Hannah was still looking at him when he came out of his post-orgasm daze. She let her legs slide from his shoulders, and her pussy massaged him as she did, making him grimace with the overpowering pleasure-pain of her movement. His cock was still hard, buried inside of her, and his mind was still in overdrive, conjuring image after image of his wife being fucked by August Healy.

Hannah squirmed beneath him, and then his cock was out of her body and he felt her hand squeezing him. She was impressed, he could tell, that he was still hard. Mike felt sure Gus had been the same way.

Hannah took the lead now, pushing him by one shoulder to turn and recline against the armrest at the end of the couch. He stared, almost disbelieving, as his wife grinned and started to move back down his body.

Her left hand was on his cock, her wedding ring glinting as she moved her hand in smooth strokes that cackled with wetness. Her lips hovered over his crown, and she looked up at him, still stroking. “Do you want me to show you how I cleaned his cock off after he fucked me?”

Mike was unable to say anything. His hand went to the back of her head, not to push her down, just to touch her. Her tongue flicked from between her lips and landed, hot and wet, on his crown.

He watched her as she went to work, giving him the best blowjob he had ever gotten in his life. She ran her tongue along the length of his shaft, then in circles around his crown, actually licking all the cum and pussy juice – his, Gus’s, and her own – from his flesh.

Only after she completed that, and his cock was bobbing wildly in the air, did she take him into her mouth, swallowing him up in her silky flesh all the way to the base of his cock.

Her tongue moved on the underside of his dick, and then he was thrown with an arching back against the couch. His fingers clamped on her hair when he felt her tongue slide out and tickle his balls.

She released his cock after traveling up to the crown again, with a wet slurp. He stared at her, meeting her eyes. Her hand stroked his cock. “Gus taught me a new trick,” she purred. “Do you like it?”

He wasn’t sure if he said anything, because she was back at it again, her lips sliding down his shaft, then hot on his balls, then her tongue, wet and quick, stroking the tender flesh of his testicles from between his cock and her own lip.

She did this again and again, her face becoming filthier with saliva, mingled with the cum of two men and her own pussy.

He couldn't take it anymore, he pushed on the back of her head and tilted his hips, his cock deep in her throat, when he came.

He could feel one, then two, and then a final third spurt against the back of her throat. He let his hand drop, but she sucked all the cum right out of him, and then licked it from his cock.

She then placed herself above his cock, straddling him.

“Oh no, Hannah,” he said. “I can’t...”

But his voice was cut off, strangled by the paroxysm of pleasure and pain that grasped him by the balls as she guided his sensitive dick to the hard button in her soaked folds. She began to stroke her clit with the tip of his dick.

His abdomen seized, he had to do a partial sit up to maintain any control over himself whatsoever. He gripped her hips and watched as she moved his cock around in her soaked, filthy folds. A big glob of his cum – maybe his, maybe Gus’s - rolled onto his shaft and dribbled down the underside of his cock.

Sticky, wet sucking sounds filled the room as she masturbated with the end of his dick, until she made herself come. Her pussy gushed over the top of his dick, which was doing its best to come back to life. The hot, sticky liquid rolled down to his balls, and his wife, her pussy pulsing and gushing, sank slowly onto his dick. Her eyes were closed, and she was exhausted.

His cock pulsed to life inside of her, and he gripped her hips and helped her ride him until he came again. She was tired, her face a sticky wet mess, her hair tousled, and her eyes half open. But she was helping him, riding him slowly at first, and then faster, her own needs gripping her again.

Because they had both come so many times already, it took a long time for them to pant and grind to a mutual orgasm. He was helped along as she clawed at his chest and leaned back, still bouncing on his dick, to mewl: “Oh, my pussy’s so soooooore. Don’t stop, though.”

She collapsed against the back of the sofa after she came, and they lay like that for a good long time, too sweaty and tired to move.

He realized that she had essentially fallen asleep. After all, she had been fucking Gus all night, and now him, and her body was utterly used and worn-out.

She stirred a little as he slid out from under her, pulled her feet up to the couch, and covered her with a blanket. He almost let her sleep there, but then decided – back injuries be damned – that he had better lift and put his naked, cum-stained wife to bed. In *their* bed.

*

Hannah rolled over and was not at all surprised to see her husband staring at her, his head propped up by one hand, elbow bent into a pillow.

The memories of everything that had happened barreled immediately into her mind, and she felt a wash of red roll over her face. She had the taste of cum – not one guy’s, but two – in her mouth, and she could feel the slight pinch of dried cum on her cheek, her forehead, her inner thighs.

She was such a filthy slut.

A cold wave of guilt rolled through her chest.

It was quickly overtaken, though, by Mike's tender expression. His fingers pushed some stray hair out of her face and he leaned forward to kiss her.

It seemed strange – hell, it probably was strange – that her husband really wanted all this. She hadn't fully believed it until this very moment. Even after he told her to do it, she continued to think, all night at the club, that he was actually just testing her loyalty.

One thing had led to another, though, and she had started making out with Gus on the dance floor. But then guilt had overtaken her, and she had told him she couldn't go through with it.

At some point, she had revealed to Gus that her husband had told her to do it, and that's when Gus had smiled knowingly and told her all about hotwives, and bulls. Which she had also not really believed, until he took her home and showed her the videos and the forums. And somewhere in that time he had kissed her neck, had slid his hands down her sweater and found her breasts, had arranged her on the desk, knocking the computer off, and they were fucking passionately before she could even think of what to say.

It was afterward, when she had felt guilty, still unsure of what to make of what Gus was telling her, and what her husband had said, that Gus offered to coach her on what to tell her husband. How to tell him dirty, tantalizing versions of the truth.

And the fact that the coaching had been very hands-on?

She was surprised that she had done it. Surprised by how much she had liked it. Surprised that when Gus told her to get on her knees and look him in the eye while she swallowed his cum, that she had enjoyed it.

Even more surprising was that she had also enjoyed imagining how she would tell her husband about it, the thrill of thinking that he wanted to be watching her, wanted her to be giving herself to the sexual whims of another man...

Hannah put her hand to her forehead. Mike kissed her again.

It was true, he really *was* into this.

"Hey," she said.

"Hey yourself," he said. He moved her hand from her forehead. "That was amazing. I can't believe you did it."

She smiled sheepishly. "Neither can I."

And then a long pause, while his hands explored her body.

"So what's next?" he said, finally, maybe a minute later, maybe half an hour. Hannah's mind was blank except for his hands over her hips, her pussy, her breasts. She wasn't even thinking of Gus, at least not directly: he was peripheral to all of this somehow.

Was it possible to realize how much she loved her husband by sleeping with another man?

Her chest felt tight.

"I don't know," she whispered.

Her eyes met Mike's.

"I love you," he said.

"I love you," she answered.

EPILOGUE

The phone call came just as she was leaving for work, and her phone buzzed in her pocket at almost exactly the same time the woman on the other end mentioned the Lightning Bolt Award.

Hannah had reprogrammed Gus's number as "Gus," because it no longer made any sense for her to hide it from her husband. A couple of weeks had gone by, and she had been stalling him, wondering if she should see him again or not.

She and Mike spent a lot of time talking about it, after hot sex, and while they lay on pillows, looking at each other. It was like they had fallen in love all over again.

On the one hand, Hannah thought she should just let this whole thing be a part of their past. She didn't want complications. Maybe it was just supposed to be a one-time thing.

She liked Gus, but she *loved* Mike, and maybe it had taken putting her husband in relief to see that again.

On the other hand, she could feel the heat slowly evaporating again from their sex life. How long would this re-charge last? Maybe Gus was just the sort of thing that she could do as maintenance.

That scared her, too, though. Because right now, she thought of him as a fling. Would she start getting emotional about him if she saw him again?

She looked at the cell phone in her hand as the woman on the landline talked in her ear.

[Gus]: *Did the lawyer call you yet? Get a lightning bolt after all. And... a free trip.*

The woman on the other end of the line was saying, right at that moment, "...Huxton, the man whose life you saved, would like to pay for your expenses so you can attend the ceremony here and, if you're comfortable with it, meet Mr. Huxton and his family. He's very grateful you were there."

Hannah stared at her phone.

It was standard practice, if a victim of cardiac arrest was successfully resuscitated, that the team saving his life would be awarded what was called the Lightning Bolt Award. Hannah now had so many that she had lost track, as most paramedics did after a decade on the job.

What was *not* standard was receiving the award when you were off-duty at the time of the incident, and definitely not standard, the victim having a lawyer contact you about an expense-paid trip to attend the ceremony. Two things occurred to her: Mr. Hux-whatever must have pulled some strings, and he was probably very wealthy.

“Miss Moore?” the attorney said. “Are you still there?”

Hannah’s mobile phone buzzed.

[Gus]: *So you coming or what? I can think of a few things I want to show you in Denver.*

Hannah’s chest seized up and her mouth fell open. “Uh,” she managed to say. “I... can you maybe, I need some time to think about... the details.”

“Of course Miss Moore. And Mr. Huxton has authorized me to work with you on the dates of your trip in order to be as accommodating as possible of your schedule. I’ve spoken to Mr. Healy and he assured me he can accommodate you as well. Do you have an email address I can send the details to?”

Hannah gave her email address numbly, her fingers running over the screen of her phone.

I can think of a few things I want to show you in Denver.

A whole weekend, in Denver? With only one thing to do besides see what Gus had to show her?

The phone – her home phone, which she had answered - began to blare in her hand. Evidently the call from the attorney had ended.

She rested the antiquated phone on the cradle and stared at her own cellphone.

Her chest expanded, her body filled with adrenaline. She could feel herself throbbing between her legs.

But it was 10:02.

She pumped ice water back into her veins, and got in her car to drive to work.

She would have to think about all of this later.

Right now, she had a job to do.

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

Working On Her Game

Will has landed a lucrative position at a law firm in New Mexico, but the transition to the slow-moving, scorching Southwest has been a strain on his marriage. His wife has surprised him by taking up a new sport to fill her time. But it isn't long before the couple discover that Scarlett's new instructor can give her a lot more than just tennis lessons. Her dark, handsome tennis coach might have just the thing their marriage needs...

Don't forget to check out *Game For More*, the sequel to *Working On Her Game*

A Taste For Teasing

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blond, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his

fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Interracial Hotwife Bundle

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

Claudia Changes Tack

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken.

But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Lisa Plays Her Part

Lisa and Luke married young because of an unexpected pregnancy, and Lisa never had much experience with other men as a result. But when a dark, handsome, wealthy man she almost slept with (and always wondered about) resurfaces in her life, Lisa is confronted with agonizing desires... and choices. Now that their nest is empty and they don't have the same reasons to stay together, will Lisa and Luke reconnect, or will Lisa choose to make this the final act of their marriage?

Megyn For The Win

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn – one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor - the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

Hotwife Suspense By Arnica Butler

Nila's Long Con

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of A Well-Laid Trap, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

A Well-Laid Trap

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

Fun Summer Swinger Titles:

Clothing Optional

Sy Price and his wife find themselves in an unexpected situation when their Belize vacation resort turns out to be "Clothing Optional." They're even more surprised to find out that "Clothing Optional" is code for quite a bit more. They decide to make the best of things and enjoy their vacation. But there are a lot more surprises in store for Sy when Jackie decides to fully embrace the hotel amenities...

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless. Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties. One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

*Explore **darker** themes by Arnica Butler:*

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries

they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.